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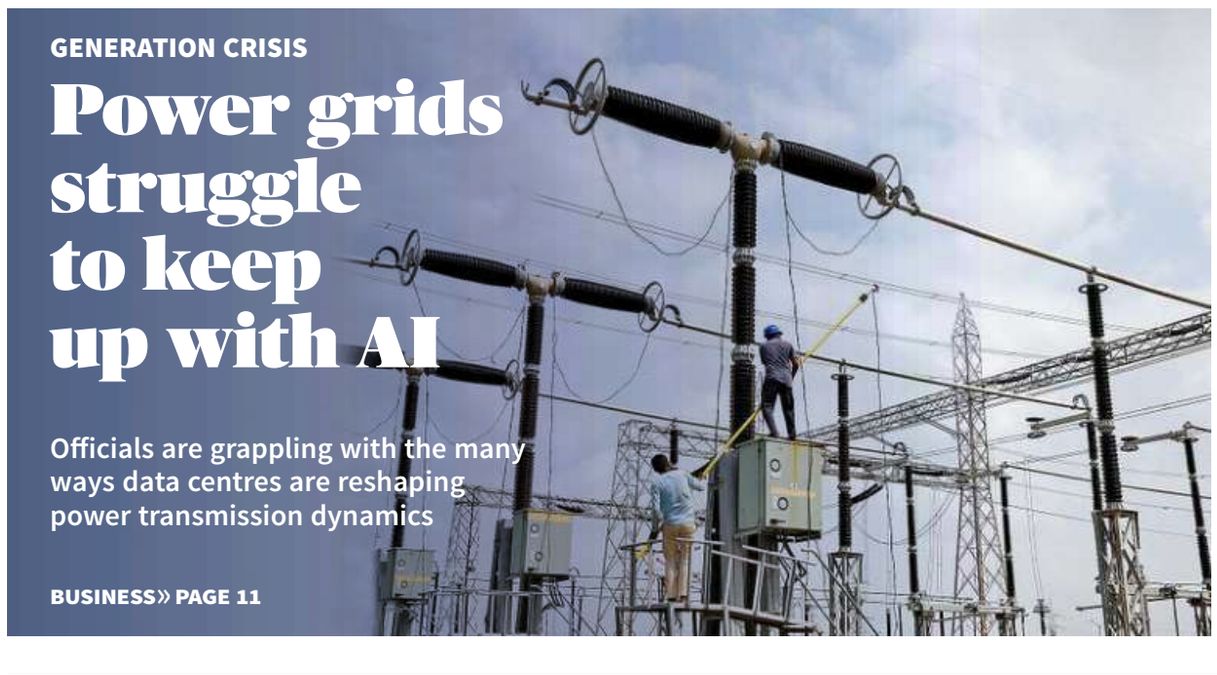
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GENERATION CRISIS

Power grids struggle to keep up with AI

Officials are grappling with the many ways data centres are reshaping power transmission dynamics

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Trump strikes deal to obtain diesel from Russia

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T.N. may encounter El Niño differently from rest of India

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Shreyas' men will look to hit back in third T20I

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INSIDE



NIA to investigate attack on pilot of flydubai plane

NEW DELHI
The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has registered a case over the alleged mid-air hijacking attempt of an Israel-bound flydubai flight and the attack on its Indian pilot Captain Smit Machchhar on September 30. » PAGE 5

Centre initiates probe on Pen-G, salts from China

HYDERABAD
India initiated an anti-dumping probe into imports of Penicillin G and its salts from China after manufacturer Lyfius Pharma alleged the imports were causing material retardation to the industry. » PAGE 11



RBI opens special dollar window for PSU oil firms

MUMBAI
The RBI announced a dollar window to meet the daily foreign exchange requirements of three public sector oil marketing companies, to ease pressure on rupee amid rising crude oil prices. » PAGE 11

Thousands detained in capital clampdown

Heavy security, transport curbs fail to stop inflow of protesters calling for CEC's resignation to Delhi

Ex-Chief Ministers, journalists and lawyers among those held by police; several picked up overnight

AISA tries to reassemble participants at Dilli Haat; detainees except CJP leaders released by evening

Shrimansi Kaushik
Lavpreet Kaur
Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Despite heavy security arrangements, severe transport restrictions, and an Internet shutdown, protesters on Saturday managed to reach locations near Jantar Mantar in central Delhi to demand the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over alleged electoral irregularities.

With the designated protest site inaccessible, protesters led by All India Students Association (AISA) president Neha Bora attempted to assemble at Dilli Haat in south Delhi before being detained.

According to Delhi Police sources, nearly 2,500 protesters were detained across the capital during the day, indicating a high turnout despite the absence of prominent Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders on the ground.

A few journalists were also detained. These were in addition to around 1,000 people picked up in preventive operations across Delhi overnight ahead of the protest.

Several lawyers who were also detained were released following an intervention by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant.

While YouTuber Dhruv Rathee was detained from his residence in the morning, CJP leaders Abhijeet Dipke, Ashutosh Ranka, and Saurav Das were taken immediately after their flight from Mumbai landed at Delhi airport. The CJP leaders had publicly announced their visit on social media, urging supporters to assemble at Jantar Mantar at 10 a.m. on Saturday for what they described as the "Final Call to Save Democracy."

All detainees except the CJP team were released by late evening.

Connaught Place, one of Delhi's busiest commercial hubs, wore a deserted look amid an "unprecedented" security deployment in recent times, with multiple layers of barricading and the police severely restricting public movement.

All roads leading to Jantar Mantar were barricaded, with loudspeakers warning people of legal action if they defied police instructions.



On their toes: Security personnel rush to disperse protesters near Connaught Place in New Delhi on Saturday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Detention centres

The youth-led protest, called by Left groups, the CJP, and civil society groups, kept the police and security forces on their toes as they forcibly removed the protesters, put them in buses, and took them to large halls and stadiums on the outskirts of Delhi that had been converted into detention centres.

Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) leaders, including four former Chief Ministers – Mamata Banerjee, Pinarayi Vijayan, Manik Sarkar, and Arvind Kejriwal – were also among those detained.

The CJP and the Students Federation of India (SFI) announced that protest march to Jantar Mantar would be organised every day till the CEC resigns.

New Delhi was virtually fortified on Saturday, with over 20,000 security personnel, including Central Armed Police Force and the Delhi Police, holding vigil from early morning till late in the day, preventing protesters from entering the district, let alone reaching Jantar Mantar.

With 45 Metro stations shut, over 200 trains arriving in Delhi cancelled, schools and colleges suspending classes, and marketplaces across central Delhi closed, protesters continued to find ways to reach the site, with some walking several miles.

The borders of the National Capital were also barricaded, and incoming vehicles monitored.

A large number of protesters were detained at the borders. Police also held "*aman*" (peace) meetings with members of various communities to discourage them from participating in the protest. Loudspeaker announcements warned people about Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) being in place in New Delhi, prohibiting any rally.

Protesters were detained from Rajghat, Janpath, Connaught Place, Ashoka Road, Gurudwara Bangla Saheb and ITO, and taken to locations on the outskirts, including Burari, Nangloi, Mundka, Shalimar Bagh and Ashok Nagar.

The flashpoint of the protest was the Safdarjung flyover, where Ms. Bora tried to enter New Delhi district to march towards Jantar Mantar.

While the police detained the student leader and many of her associates, several protesters who were unable to reach the site due to the high security deployment, reached the spot of the AISA protest in Dilli Haat.

MORE REPORTS ON
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Stopping crowd from regrouping a challenging task

Though the Centre succeeded in preventing protesters from converging at Jantar Mantar on Saturday, its next challenge appeared to be stopping the largely "leaderless" crowd from regrouping. » PAGE 3

Rahul lends support to protesters

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Saturday urged the protesting students to carry on without fear and stand up for what they believe in. » PAGE 3

Youth bodies vow to sustain stir till CEC Kumar quits

Leaders of youth and student organisations on Saturday vowed to continue their protest until all their demands, including the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) were met. » PAGE 4

Concerned by 'mass detentions' in Delhi: UN body

Office of the United Nations Human Rights Commissioner said it was "concerned" by reports of "mass detentions" in Delhi, a statement that the Centre rejected. » PAGE 5

Woman among five persons killed in Manipur clashes

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

At least five people, a woman among them, have been killed in clashes between armed groups and attacks on villages in separate incidents in Manipur's Kamjong and Ukhrul districts since Friday evening.

Two Naga civilians were also reported missing from the Litan area in Ukhrul district, where a Gurkha farmer from Senapati district, identified as 40-year-old Sandeep Rai, was gunned down while driving on the Mahadev-Talui road on Saturday. Former Manipur Chief Minister Nongthombam Biren Singh and people living along the India-Myanmar border said that seven people had died in the renewed violence.

The two additional deaths that they claimed were reportedly members of the extremist Kuki National Army (Burma), which allegedly attacked Naga border villages in the Naga-majority Kamjong district. These deaths were not officially confirmed

The attacks and resultant casualties followed a security operation carried out between October 4 and 7, during which the Indian Army and the paramilitary Assam Rifles detected and defused 27 improvised explosive devices planted along an 8-km stretch of the Myanmar border in Kamjong district.

In the first incident, a 42-year-old Kuki woman named Domkhonei Touthang was shot dead in Chassad Kuki village in Kamjong district on Friday night.

The gunfight between armed groups in the area continued till Saturday morning, also resulting in the death of 22-year-old Michael Ngamminlen Haokip.

The Working Committee of the Tangkhul Naga Long (WC-TNL) alleged Kuki extremists had fired at a team of the Indian Reserve Battalion (IRB) on routine patrolling duty in Chassad Kuki village, leading to the gunfight that started Friday night.



Continuing hostilities: The attacks followed a security operation between October 4 and 7 along the Myanmar border. FILE PHOTO

'Routine affair'

The Naga organisation further alleged that the Kuki extremists launched an armed offensive against Naga civilians on Saturday and set ablaze nine houses in Kamjong, the district headquarters. It said two Naga civil defence volunteers – B.S. Honreipam and Ringphami Jajo – sustained gunshot wounds.

The WC-TNL said the Kuki extremists attacked Ningchou village in the same district later in the day, killing two Naga civilians identified as Ngachanso Ningshen and Leishisan Leishadang.

The Myanmar-based extremists also reportedly set a police station in Kamjong on fire. "The external aggression against Naga villagers of Kamjong bordering Myanmar has become a routine affair since the outbreak of violent conflict in the hills of Manipur," the WC-TNL said.

On the other hand, Kuki organisations blamed the killing of community members on the IRB and the extremist National Socialist Council of Nagalim, also known as the Isak-Muivah faction of the NSCN.

"The IRB personnel attempted to forcibly disperse the Chassad Village Guards, who have been defending their ancestral village with their lives, from their legitimate posts... When the brave women of Chassad came forward to defend their Village Guards, the IRB personnel in a most cowardly, inhumane and indiscriminate manner opened fire upon the unarmed womenfolk, resulting in the death of Domkhonei Touthang," the Kuki Students' Organisation said.

It demanded the immediate registration of an FIR and arrest of all IRB personnel involved in the killing, immediate ex-gratia and justice for the family of the deceased, a high-level independent inquiry by the Central government into the alleged infiltration of NSCN (I-M) cadres into the IRB, and the withdrawal of "such biased" State forces.

Manipur's Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen and the Kuki Inpi Manipur, an apex tribal body, condemned the killing of the two Kuki civilians in Kamjong district and the Gurkha farmer in Ukhrul district. They sought interventions from the Centre, the State government, and human rights organisations.

The fresh wave of violence occurred on a day that Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh met Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi.



Security breach: Thick black smoke rising from the King Khalid Airport in Riyadh after the previ0ous attack on Friday. AP

Several hurt in Saudi Arabia airport attack

Associated Press
CAIRO

Amid growing hostilities with the Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen, Saudi Arabian officials on Saturday said the airport in capital Riyadh was attacked again.

A missile struck a complex housing terminals 3 and 4 for domestic flights and many people were wounded, an official said.

The attack comes days after three Saudi Arabian citizens were killed as the kingdom faces a series of assaults in the new front in the Iran war.

U.S. President Donald Trump said he was evaluating whether to join Saudi's strikes against the Houthis.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

6 years on, PM to inaugurate CMRL Phase 2 stretch today

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Six years since the work on the Chennai Metro Rail Limited's (CMRL) Phase 2 network began, the first train from Porur Bypass is all set to run till Poonamallee on Sunday morning, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay among the first few commuters.

While the first stretch of the project will be opened from Poonamallee to Vadapalani (15 km) for commuters, Mr. Modi and Mr. Vijay will only travel between Poonamallee and Porur Bypass.

After the flag-off around 11.30 a.m., the Phase 2 project will be inaugurated, along with a slew of other projects, at the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras (IIT-Madras) around 2 p.m. Only after the event concludes around 4 p.m. will commuters be allowed to use the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch.

Train services on this stretch will operate from 7 a.m. to 9 p.m., unlike those on the Phase 1 network, which run from 5 a.m. to 11 p.m. Sources said this was to facilitate the construction of stations from Porur Junction to Vadapalani - Alapakkam, Karambakkam, Valasaravakkam, Alwarthirunagar, Saligramam Warehouse, and Saligramam - at night.

Initially, 15 trains will run from Poonamallee to Vadapalani. Commuters can access a train every 10 minutes during the peak hours.



Panelists at the launch of a book by former Madras High Court judge K. Chandru at the Asian College of Journalism in Chennai. M. SRINATH

Ex-Chief Justice says executive's grip over judiciary has tightened

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The grip of the executive over judicial appointments to the constitutional courts, and particularly of the Chief Justice of India, has progressively tightened since May 2014, said Justice S. Muralidhar, former Chief Justice, High Court of Orissa.

Delivering an address during the presentation of the book *Who will judge the judges* by retired judge of Madras High Court K. Chandru, at the Asian College of Journalism in Chennai on Saturday, Justice Muralidhar said: "The collegium system as in the last 12 years has undergone a steady transformation. Today we have a situation where the primacy as in practice has shifted back to the executive. The government has steadily extended its grip over the appointments and transfers of judges and chief justices of High Courts... It can be stated with reasonable certainty, that for the next 10 years in the Supreme Court and for several more years in the High Courts, there will be judges who will owe their position to the current political establishment and the members of the collegium that appointed them. This forebodes not too well for the future of the judiciary".

R. Vaigai, Senior Advocate, Madras High Court, said the judiciary should not only act as the guardian of the Constitution and the Laws but also play a transformative and empowering role.

Asian College of Journalism and Media Development Foundation Chairman Sashi Kumar said: "Surely what is often characterised as one of the most powerful judiciaries of the world falls short in its exertions to safeguard what, again, is considered one of the finest written Constitutions in the world, particularly at a time when the Constitution is, insidiously and palpably, under attack by the ruling dispensation of the day."

The Hindu Director N. Ram presented the book *Who will judge the judges* to the panelists.

Modi, Shah have thrown the nation into turmoil: CPI(M)

Party stages protests across Keralam against detention of leaders in Delhi; slams govt. for 'shielding CEC' and creating a 'lockdown-like situation'; CM calls Pinarayi's detention arbitrary, seeks release

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The CPI(M) Keralam State secretariat on Saturday strongly condemned the detention of several protesters, including senior party leaders, by the Delhi Police ahead of a march to Jantar Mantar seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, describing it as a "fascist action" by the Union government to suppress dissent.

State-wide stir

The party also organised protests across Keralam, including in Kannur and Alappuzha, against the detentions and alleged police high-handedness.



CPI(M) workers take out a protest march in Kannur on Saturday against the arrest of party leaders in New Delhi. S.K. MOHAN

The CPI(M) said Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah were plunging the entire nation into turmoil in a bid to protect the CEC. The BJP owed an explanation as to why it created an atmosphere akin to a lockdown by deploying more than 50,000 police personnel and paramilitary forces and imposing prohibitory orders.

"The Internet has been shut down in Delhi and 57 Metro stations have been closed. Trains that left for Delhi terminated their service before reaching Delhi. All these actions curb freedom of movement and expression. When the CPI(M) general secretary approached the Supreme Court, the court disagreed with such prohibitions," the party said.

Satheesan's stance

In a post on X, Mr. Vijayan said: "Delhi is witnessing the Modi government's brutal crackdown on democracy," and that protesters and journalists being detained.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said on X that he was deeply concerned about the arbitrary detention of Mr. Vijayan. He strongly condemned the act and said the Chief Secretary and the Resident Commissioner in New Delhi were in direct contact with the Delhi Police authorities to secure Mr. Vijayan's immediate release.

HC asks T.N. govt. to draft rules for ride aggregators

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has directed the State government to examine the report of an expert committee and frame suitable guidelines/rules/by-laws in six months for aggregators, including those related to bike-taxi services.

A Division Bench of Justices P. Velmurugan and K.K. Ramakrishnan issued the direction while disposing of a public interest litigation (PIL) petition that had sought a direction to the State government to enact and enforce a comprehensive legal and regulatory framework governing aggregators.

The State submitted that after carefully examining the proposal in the light of the Motor Vehicle Aggregator Guidelines, 2025, the government had issued a G.O. constituting a seven-member expert committee to examine the existing categories of vehicles; collect and analyse relevant data; study prevailing fare structures and best practices adopted elsewhere; examine issues relating to dynamic pricing, pooling services, aggregator-driver agreements, and monitoring mechanisms; and recommend a fair, transparent, and reasonable fare regime for incorporation in the Tamil Nadu Motor Vehicle Aggregator Rules, 2025.

The court directed the matter to be listed after six months.

Discontent brews in Karnataka Cong.

Nagesh Prabhu
BENGALURU

Discontent is simmering among some Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) legislators and Ministers over Cabinet expansion, fund allocation and alleged interference in constituencies, posing a fresh challenge to Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar's efforts to keep the flock united.

The growing discontent has also brought Mr. Shivakumar's relationship with KPCC president B.K. Hariprasad under scrutiny, with the two reportedly differing on several organisational issues.

While the first half of the Congress government's five-year term was marked by differences between former Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and Mr. Shivakumar, the second half appears to be witnessing public confrontations between some Ministers and legislators. The discontent has surfaced in Shivamogga, Vijayapura, Mysuru, Kolar-Chickballapur and Belagavi districts.

In Shivamogga, tensions have surfaced between School Education Minister and the district in-charge Madhu Bangarappa and Belur Gopalakrishna, Sagar MLA, who was denied a Cabinet berth. Mr. Gopalakrishna has criticised what he described as "favouritism towards political dynasties".

In Vijayapura, differences between Minister M.B. Patil and Congress MLAs C.S. Nadagouda and Yashvantharayagouda Patil have escalated. The legislators have accused Mr. Patil of conspiring to prevent them from securing ministerial berths.

An 'open war'

Yashvantharayagouda Patil had threatened to resign as MLA over the failure to declare his Indi constituency drought-hit. He has also declared an "open war" against the Minister, saying the 2028 Assembly election would become a direct contest between the two.

INBRIEF



Appraiser held for replacing gold with fake jewels in bank

The Andhra Pradesh on Saturday arrested a gold appraiser who worked at the Bank of Baroda's Kakinada branch for allegedly replacing gold jewellery pledged with the bank with imitation ornaments. The accused was identified as Narava Suribabu, 59. Nearly 1.2 kg of gold jewellery was seized from him. The police say he absconded after replacing the gold jewels pledged against 44 gold loan accounts. A case has been registered against Suribabu under Section 316(4) of the BNS for criminal breach of trust, which carries a punishment of up to seven years in prison.

Hyderabad cyber police arrest 35 across nine States

The Hyderabad Cyber Crime Police arrested 35 persons across nine States in connection with 23 cybercrime cases during September, while facilitating refunds of ₹88.48 lakh to victims of online fraud. As per a monthly report, the Cyber Crime Police Station registered 83 FIRs during the month. The arrests included nine persons involved in social media-related offences, seven in investment fraud, six in digital arrest scams, five in trading fraud, three in advertisement fraud, two in identity theft and one each in extortion, job fraud and customer care fraud.

Expert team begins operation to tranquillise tiger in A.P.

A team led by noted wildlife conservationist Tuhin Satarkar began efforts to tranquillise the transient male tiger, Explorer, which has been prowling near human habitations nearly 20 km from Rajamahendravaram in Andhra Pradesh. The Pune-based RESQ Charitable Trust is in charge of the mission. The tiger from Maharashtra had first entered Chhattisgarh and Telangana, and then reached Andhra Pradesh.

Festive blooms



Flower fiesta: Women carry flowers during the first day of Bathukamma festival at Kukatpally in Hyderabad on Saturday. The festival, which will be celebrated for nine days during Dasara, will end with 'Saddula Bathukamma'. NAGARA GOPAL

ED moves Telangana HC to expedite PMLA cases against Jagan

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has approached the Telangana High Court seeking directions for the speedy, day-to-day trial of money laundering cases against YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) president and former Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy and others, citing prolonged delays in proceedings that have remained pending for nearly a decade. The agency filed a writ petition on September 23, seeking directions to expedite the trial and ensure the personal appearance of all accused in the prosecution complaints filed under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

The ED said it had filed nine prosecution complaints against Jagan Mohan Reddy and others before the Special Court for CBI cases in Nampally, Hyderabad, between 2016 and 2021. Although cognisance has been taken in all nine complaints, the cases remain at a preliminary stage, with discharge petitions awaiting hearings.

ED pointed out that despite several years having elapsed since cognisance was taken, there had been no significant progress in the proceedings. It said the pendency of discharge petitions had delayed further progress in the prosecution complaints.

Wayanad seeks to get e-waste-free district status by November

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Wayanad aims to become the country's first e-waste-free model district by November 1, 2026.

The campaign has entered its second phase, focusing on collecting electronic waste from households and private establishments following the removal of 31 tonnes from government offices across the district.

Kerala Agriculture Minister T. Siddique said on Saturday that the campaign was a step towards making the district waste-free and promoting scientific waste management. The second phase will be implemented with the support of local self-government institutions, elected representatives, and Haritha Karma Sena members.

E-waste will be collected through counters at the ward level and door-to-door drives before being handed over to agencies for scientific processing and disposal.

People will receive compensation for the waste they hand over.

This 'Trojan Horse' in Kochi draws attention to dangers of digital world

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

An installation unveiled at c0c0n 2026, the cybersecurity and hacking conference in Kochi, Keralam, has turned out to be a "symbol of cyber awareness".

Titled "The Trojan Project", India's first Cyber Trojan Horse, the 25-feet-tall statue of a horse has been created by artist DaVinci Suresh using discarded electronic scrap, including motherboards, processors, circuit boards, cables, and other electronic components. "The installation draws inspiration from the legendary Trojan Horse, a symbol of danger concealed behind an apparently harmless or attractive exterior. By bringing this concept to life through a monumental installation, the project seeks to make the risks of the digital world more tangible and understandable to the public," according to the organisers of the event.

The installation also highlights the importance of responsible electronic waste management and recycling, demonstrating how electronic waste can be repurposed to create a meaningful public awareness initiative.



The Trojan Project

Mr. Suresh said that it took a month and half to complete the project. "There are plans to shift it to Nehru Park in Fort Kochi as a permanent installation. If the plan succeeds, necessary changes will be made in its structure," he said.

Safe cyberspace

The installation has been launched in partnership with Childlight - Global Child Safety Institute, a data institute hosted by the University of Edinburgh.

The collaboration aims to use the monument's visibility and symbolic significance to raise awareness of online child sexual exploitation and abuse and extend the message to audiences worldwide.

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Congress leader Rahul Gandhi interacts with a student during an event in Chennai on Saturday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Carry on without fear, Rahul tells student protesters

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Saturday urged the protesting students in Delhi to carry on without fear and stand up for what they believe in, even in the face of a state crackdown through large-scale detentions and Internet shutdowns.

Speaking at a *Maanavargalin Kural* (voice of students) event here on Saturday, Mr. Gandhi said Prime Minister Narendra Modi was attempting to silence dissenting voices through such crackdowns, oblivious of the fact that his "game is over".

"He is silencing voices, as you saw today in New Delhi. The entire city was shut down, Internet was shut down, the police were beating students," Mr. Gandhi said.

When a participant expressed concerns over the detention of students, journalists, and lawyers, without dignity and respect, Mr. Gandhi replied: "I want to make it very clear to every single student who is protesting not only in Delhi [but] across the country: You have nothing to fear. We are with you and we are going to make sure that Mr. Narendra Modi, Amit Shah, [RSS chief] Mohan Bhagwat, [National Security Adviser] Ajit Doval, and this group of conspirators who have destroyed Indian democracy, who are using [CEC] Gyanesh Kumar to steal elections, are brought to justice."

Delhi Police treated us like criminals, says Mamata

Former West Bengal CM and former CMs Pinarayi Vijayan, Arvind Kejriwal and Manik Sarkar wanted to join the protesters to show solidarity; CPI(M) leaders managed to reach Jantar Mantar

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI



Pinarayi Vijayan (left) at Jantar Mantar and Mamata Banerjee in a police van after being detained by the police during a protest against the CEC in New Delhi on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA, ANI

The police detained four former Chief Ministers, Pinarayi Vijayan, Mamata Banerjee, Arvind Kejriwal and Manik Sarkar, who wanted to join the youth groups' protests in Delhi on Saturday.

Mr. Vijayan, former Keralam Chief Minister, was picked up from Kerala House, close to Jantar Mantar. Former West Bengal Chief Minister Ms. Banerjee was picked up from the South Avenue bus stand, right in front of the flats allotted to parliamentarians.

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) leadership managed to take the police by surprise after staying overnight at Kerala House, which is just a few metres from Jantar Mantar – a location that the police sought to make completely out of bounds for protesters. Party leaders, including general secretary M.A. Baby and senior leaders Brinda Karat, John Brittas, K.N. Balagopal, K.K. Shailaja, P. Sivadasan, and P. Rajeeve, marched out of Kerala House towards Jantar Mantar, shouting slogans. They were detained immediately by the police.

In a video message posted on social media, Ms. Karat said, "Amit Shah *dekh lo, hum pahunch gaye Jantar Mantar* (Look Amit Shah, we have reached Jantar Mantar)". The group was split up, and Mr. Vijayan, along with others, were taken to Chattarasal Stadium.

Forty minutes later, Mr. Vijayan, along with Mr. Brittas and Mr. Balagopal, were again put into a police jeep and taken to a different location. "If a person who served as Chief Minister for 10 years is treated like this, imagine the plight of the common man. Delhi is under siege and basic civil liberties are being taken away," Mr. Brittas, a Rajya Sabha MP, said.

A few hours later, Ms. Banerjee, who was sitting on a *dharna* at the South Avenue bus stand, right in front of the MPs' flats, along with Rajya Sabha MPs Derek O'Brien and Dola Sen, Lok Sabha MPs Protima Mandal and Samirul Islam, and former MP Saket Gokhale, was picked by the Delhi Police.

Speaking over the phone from Dwarka North police station, Ms. Banerjee said that she and her colleagues were treated like "criminals" despite just six of them sitting peacefully without raising slogans or holding placards. "The Delhi Police treated us like criminals, like murderers. We were put in a prison van and driven for two hours around Delhi. It is the first time in my political career that I have sat in a prison van," Ms. Banerjee said. She likened Saturday's clampdown by the government across Delhi to "doomsday".

"I was going to return to Kolkata by a 9 p.m. flight, [but] I have decided to stay back. I will march along with other INDIA bloc leaders to the Supreme Court," she said.

Former Delhi Chief Minister Mr. Kejriwal and former Tripura Chief Minister Mr. Sarkar were also detained by the police.

Stopping return of 'leaderless' crowd a challenge for govt.

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Though the Union government succeeded in preventing protesters seeking Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation from converging at Jantar Mantar on Saturday, its next challenge appeared to be stopping the largely "leaderless" crowd from regrouping in the coming days.

After a hearing in the Supreme Court on Friday regarding the restrictions in Delhi, the government had considered offering Ramlila Maidan as an alternative protest site to the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), officials claimed. But, they said, the organisers had not requested this.

Pellet guns, which injured four people on July 20 during the protest demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, were withdrawn from the anti-riot gear of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) for Saturday's protest. However, some Border Security Force (BSF) personnel were seen carrying a sub-machine gun.

Security dilemma

Government officials told *The Hindu* that mobilising security arrangements to the scale seen on Saturday would not be feasible in the coming days, and that keeping protesters under detention for more than 24 hours would not be legal.

The Connaught Place block, one of the busiest commercial establishments in the country, which was shut on Saturday at the request of the police, cannot be blocked off indefinitely, officials said.

Each radial leading to Jantar Mantar was blocked with barricades, and 20-30 armed police and security force personnel were deployed at each location. "Such resources may not be available indefinitely. It is impossible to keep the entire area blocked for consecutive days," said one official.

Large crowd

The official said one of the immediate challenges for authorities was managing a crowd that was not waiting for any leader or personality to lead them.

The detention of CJP leaders Abhijeet Dipke, Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das by the police as soon as their Air India flight landed at the Delhi airport on Saturday morning did not have much of an impact on the ground.

SC to hear special plea today against mass detentions, transit shutdowns

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court is hearing on Sunday a petition filed by Rajya Sabha MP and senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy against the indiscriminate detentions of leaders, former Chief Ministers, students, youths, journalists, lawyers, and others by the Delhi Police, against the rule of law and democratic dissent.

The court is also, in the special session on Sunday, hearing a contempt petition challenging the blanket shutdown of public transport, rail and Metro services designed to deter protesters converging at the national capital to demand the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Metro stations remained shut almost across the national capital, major roads were heavily barricaded with the heavy presence of security personnel, and trains to Delhi were cancelled on Saturday.

The petitions will be heard by a Bench of Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana. The sitting of the Bench on a Sunday was published in the Supreme Court causelist released on Saturday evening.

In his petition, advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi said the shutdown was in clear violation of the October 9 order of the Supreme Court, which had emphasised that the authorities must not cause any hardship or suffering to ordinary commuters through a blanket ban.

Mr. Tripathi is the lead petitioner who moved the apex court on the police action against youth protesters on July 20 during the NEET-UG protests.

He has sought a judicial order to initiate contempt proceedings against Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, and Delhi Metro Rail Corporation Chairperson D. Thara for the alleged wilful non-compliance of the court's directions. The apex court had sought compliance reports from the authorities within four days in its Friday order.

On the draw



Cong. backs protesters but stays away from CJP stir

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi had a message for protesters on the streets of the capital on Saturday: "Youth of India, I am proud of you. Keep protesting. We are standing with you." He sent it as a video message, though, as both he and his party were conspicuously absent from the agitation this weekend.

Party chief Mallikarjun Kharge accused the Centre of turning the "mother of democracy" into a "muzzled democracy".

However, Mr. Gandhi's decision to leave Delhi on Saturday, heading south to hold the latest edition of his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' student outreach programme in Chennai, raised questions about the Congress's approach to the wider agitation.

Later, party general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal appealed to citizens to join the INDIA bloc's proposed march to the Supreme Court on Monday.

"Our youth, students, lawyers, journalists, social activists, farm union leaders, YouTubers, content creators, everyone who is questioning this regime are being detained. Modi Govt has turned the 'Mother of Democracy' into a 'Muzzled Democracy'!" Mr. Kharge said.

Mr. Kharge's strong condemnation comes amid questions over the Congress's reluctance to explicitly endorse the protests called by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) and several student and youth organisations, including those affiliated to its own allies. The Congress chief said detentions, arrests, jails, lathis, and pellets could not deter the people of India, adding that "since the days of our Freedom struggle, the youth have been at the forefront of shaping the nation's destiny".

CJP member moves SC on whereabouts of Dipke, Das, Ranka

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

CJP coverage coordinator Gaurav Bharti seeks urgent hearing on Oct. 11

A *habeas corpus* petition has been filed before the Supreme Court seeking the production and release of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke, co-convener Saurav Das, spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka, and other persons allegedly detained in connection with the protest in Delhi on Saturday over issues concerning the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The petition has been instituted under Article 32 of the Constitution by Gaurav Bharti, CJP coverage coordinator, through advocates Rajesh G. Inamdar and Shashwat Anand, on behalf of the CJP leaders and other identified and unidentified persons allegedly detained or restrained in connection with the protest. The plea invoked the Supreme Court's *habeas corpus* jurisdiction to secure judicial scrutiny of the reported detentions and the immediate release of persons whose custody is found to be unauthorised by law.

In his communication to the apex court Registry, Mr. Inamdar said the petition was filed on the evening of October 10 after the persons detained in connection with the protest had not been released. The petitioner sought a hearing on Sunday before a Special Bench convening at 10.30 a.m. He stated that the petitioners had expected the detainees to be released by the evening, but were constrained to approach the top court when that did not happen.

The petition also seeks directions requiring the authorities to disclose the identities of all persons detained, the circumstances and legal basis of each detention, the authorities responsible, the grounds communicated to the persons concerned and their present whereabouts.

Tushar Gandhi among 600 detained by Mumbai Police

Snehal Mutha
Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI



In solidarity: Actor Imran Khan at the anti-CEC protest near August Kranti Maidan in Mumbai on Saturday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

On a hot afternoon, hundreds of students and youth activists started arriving at Mumbai's August Kranti Maidan to show solidarity with the protest in Delhi on Saturday for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation.

As the police barricaded the road leading to Kranti Maidan, the designated protest site, people held a protest outside the ground. "Around 600 protesters were detained in Mumbai city," said IPS officer Shailesh Balkawade.

Among the detainees were Mahatma Gandhi's great grandson Tushar Gandhi, actor Imran Khan, Shiv Sena (UBT) MLA Varun Sardesai, and former MLC Kapil Patil.

The Mumbai protest was planned by Hum Bharat Ke Log, a civil group led by Mr. Gandhi, in solidarity with the stir by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and Left groups in Delhi.

Mr. Gandhi was taken to the DN Nagar Police Station in Mumbai's Andheri West. "We will continue our protest despite detention," he said.

Before Mr. Khan was detained, he said: "I am not scared, but what is happening around here is scary." He was taken to the Tardeo police station.

The detainees raised slogans such as *"Jai Bheem"*, *"Inquilab Zindabad"*, and *"Gyanu, istifa do* [Gyanesh, resign]".

"We are not criminals, we are just showing up for the cause we believe in. But look, they are violating our freedom of speech," said Natasha Perira, a protester.

Mridula, a student associated with Disha, a student body, said, *"Humara vote churaya hai (*Our vote has been stolen). Those in power are not above the law. When outsiders attack, we retaliate, but when the attack comes from inside, from our political leaders, then we need to protest. Protest keeps going, it is not a one-day thing, today we will be detained, tomorrow more will come together." Ms. Mridula was among those detained.

Another protester, Rachita Pujari, who works in a school, said, "I have heard the difficulties certain families suffered due to SIR process. I teach their children. SIR has selectively been unfair to certain communities, including Muslims." She added, "They submitted a plethora of documents to get the voter ID, but nothing was considered valid."

BJP accuses INDIA bloc, CJP of seeking to destabilise nation

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI



Nitin Nabin

The BJP on Saturday launched a scathing attack on the Congress-led Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which it described as an Aam Aadmi Party "proxy". The BJP alleged that both groups were seeking to destabilise India at the behest of foreign powers, warning that such "sinister designs" to foment unrest would be met with a firm response.

"I warn you that the BJP and the patriotic people of the country will give you a fitting response. The attempts you are making today to create disturbance will be dealt with firmly by the Government of India. We will counter all such forces resolutely, whether they are operating from abroad or within the country," said BJP president Nitin Nabin.

Stating that efforts were underway to create an extremely serious and dangerous situation in the country, Mr. Nabin said: "And who is doing this? These are two anarchist groups: one led by Rahul Gandhi, the leader of the INDIA bloc, and the other led by CJP, an ally of Arvind Kejriwal. I want to make it clear to both these groups that the people of India are watching you closely."

"This anarchic competition you are engaged in, to see who can create the greatest instability in this country, will not succeed. The people have rejected both Rahul Gandhi's INDIA bloc, and Arvind Kejriwal and his CJP. Instead of learning from the people's verdict, you are trying to destabilise the country. You are doing this not only to pursue your political objectives but also at the behest of foreign powers," said Mr. Nabin.



Unequal force: Police personnel detain a protester during the CJP protest in Delhi on Saturday. REUTERS



Tense scene: A protester being taken away by security personnel near Connaught Place in Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Heavy deployment: Security personnel keep vigil during the protest on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA



Chorus of dissent: A crowd of protesters raises slogans near Connaught Place. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Defiance, detentions mark road to Jantar Mantar

As a massive security deployment turned Delhi into a fortress, protesters remained determined to join the demonstration seeking the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar over alleged SIR-related irregularities; with Jantar Mantar inaccessible, they broke into spontaneous protests wherever they could, raising slogans and courting detention, some smiling their way into waiting buses

Abhinay Lakshman
Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Before dawn broke over New Delhi on Saturday, tension was palpable at the Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station. Porters and taxi drivers scrambled for work, acutely aware that the government's cancellation of dozens of trains would cost them business later in the day. At rest stops and parking lots, workers kept one eye on their smartphones as whispers went around: "the public has awakened now", "looks like the police are preparing to beat up protesters", and "all eyes are now on Jantar Mantar".

Spirited individuals

Geetika, a 25-year-old software engineer, quietly left her Faridabad home before 5 a.m., careful not to wake her mother, and booked a cab to Jantar Mantar; 63-year-old Shaheena and her 36-year-old daughter Sabika Muzaffar drove from their Gurugram home, with a hand-made poster concealed in a black map-holder; and students from Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) found a way out of the campus in the dead of the night, notebooks in hand to mask themselves amongst the gaggle of journalists they knew would gather outside the Jantar Mantar protest site.

Ruma Saikia, who travelled to Delhi from Assam, had been trying to reach Jantar Mantar since 6 a.m. but could not, while 19-year-old college student Jiya spent the night in a car with her mother at the parking lot outside the Bangla Sahib Gurudwara hoping to demonstrate on Saturday morning.

Even as armed Border Security Force (BSF) personnel arrived at the Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station before daybreak to monitor exiting passengers, the Delhi Police were fortifying the entirety of New Delhi, especially the designated protest site in the heart of the national capital to prevent 'Jantar Mantar 2.0', a protest called by youth organisations, seeking Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation over alleged special intensive revision (SIR)-linked vote theft. By 9 a.m. Geetika, Shaheena, and Sabika had been detained and put on buses, some after holding a poster for 15 minutes and others after they started speaking to the press about why they felt they needed to be there.



People's demand: Economist Jean Dreze and others take part in a protest seeking the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, at Jantar Mantar on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

While the Delhi Police's deployment of security personnel across the city made citizens like Geetika feel the need to protest more intensely, sporadic acts of protest in the early morning hours of Saturday set the tone for how the day played out across several parts of Delhi.

Wherever they found themselves, protesters unfurled posters, raised slogans, and courted detention by simply smiling their way into buses.

As news of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders Abhijit Dipke, Saurav Das, and Ashutosh Ranka's detention spread, the Delhi Police managed to prevent protesters from entering the Jantar Mantar protest site throughout Saturday. However, protesters themselves had started dispersing and demonstrating wherever they could, for however long they could, before they were detained by the police.

Even as these demonstrations started spreading, senior Delhi Police personnel were seen holding debriefing sessions with security personnel on how to handle protesters at locations like the Jantar Mantar Road-Ashoka Road roundabout and the Windsor Place circle. The security personnel listened intently, as senior officers explained that using force should be the "last resort".

Noted economist, social scientist, and activist Jean Dreze had stationed himself at one entrance to the protest site with a group of JNU students associated with the Left-affiliated Students' Federation of India (SFI) from 7.30 a.m., before the group suddenly unfurled protest banners hours later in front of security personnel, and was taken away.

Simultaneously, a group of SFI student leaders, led by former JNUSU president Aishe Ghosh, started a march calling for the CEC's resignation at Gol Dak Khana Roundabout, before being chased and dragged away by security forces. Protesters following them either ran into the nearby Bangla Sahib Gurudwara for shelter or into nearby streets for a break before regrouping.

Protesters had arrived after walking for kilometres, taking public transport, and hitch-hiking, with shin guards and elbow guards worn under their clothes for protection, even as a section of the agitators egged the security forces on so they could be detained on buses and shout slogans calling for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's resignation. Slogans that echoed through this stretch of Ashoka Road from time to time included "*Tanashahi nahi chalegi* (down with dictatorship)", "*SIR radd karo* (scrap SIR)" and "*Gyanesh Kumar istifa do* (Gyanesh Kumar, resign)".

Some protesters, even as they were being taken into custody, urged the police to allow them a few moments to record videos or speak to the media.

The stand-off repeatedly spilled onto the street as protesters emerged from the gurdwara with banners and placards, attempting to resume their demonstration. The police moved in almost immediately, detaining several people and loading them into private buses being used as detention vehicles. Additional personnel, including RAF and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) units, were deployed along the stretch as the confrontation continued.

Cat-and-mouse chase

The scene soon turned into a cat-and-mouse chase, with protesters regrouping on the streets before retreating into the gurdwara to evade detention.

By late afternoon, the playbook of dispersing protesters and demonstrating wherever one was had spread. All India Students' Association (AISA) leader Neha Bora had emerged with activists, including Yogendra Yadav and senior advocate Prashant Bhushan, to lead a march to Jantar Mantar from the AIIMS area, where the student activist's detention led to further sporadic protests.

Youth bodies vow to sustain stir till CEC quits

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

Leaders of youth and student organisations on Saturday vowed to continue their protest until all their demands, including the rollback of special intensive revision (SIR) and the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar were met, despite the detention of several key organisers ahead of the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) planned demonstration in New Delhi.

"We will come back tomorrow and walk towards Jantar Mantar again," said Ajinkya Shinde, national organisation in-charge of the CJP, at a joint press conference with representatives of the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and All India Students' Federation (AISF).

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke and co-conveners Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das were detained on arrival at the Delhi airport. Hours later, SFI's Aishe Ghosh and AISA's Neha Bora were also detained along with other members of the Left front.

"All these detentions show the fascist nature of the government and how it is afraid of the youth after July's protest. They stopped buses and trains to prevent us from gathering. They stopped everything within their control except air and water. Protesters, students and citizens have all been tracked and detained," said Mr. Shinde.

He said this was just the beginning of the fight and the protests would not stop "until Gyanesh Kumar resigns".

Mr. Shinde was named to lead the protest soon after CJP's top leadership was detained. In a video message posted on X following their detention, Mr. Dipke said, "If you are watching this video, it means Ashutosh Ranka, Saurav Das, and I have been taken into custody. The movement does not end here. Ajinkya Shinde will lead the protest at Jantar Mantar for as long as we remain in detention."

Anticipating arrest, Mr. Dipke recorded the video message on Friday night.



Upon touchdown: CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke and co-conveners Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das, after landing in Delhi. PTI

Police action aboard flight raises queries over protocol

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The detention of three Cockroach Janta Party activists – Abhijeet Dipke, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka – aboard Air India flight AI 2428, after it landed in Delhi on Saturday, ahead of the group's proposed protest at Jantar Mantar, caught the airline by surprise, it is reliably learnt.

In what airport security personnel described as an unusual move, Delhi Police, accompanied by Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) officials, boarded the aircraft and took the activists into custody from their seats. The CISF is responsible for security and access control at most major airports.

The flight, which departed Mumbai at 8 a.m. and arrived in Delhi at 10.20 a.m., had its parking bay changed on the instructions of the CISF before the aircraft landed. The move took the airline's security team by surprise.

Air India has now written to the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS), seeking clarity on the applicable guidelines in such situations, the circumstances under which police personnel were permitted to board the aircraft and the apparent lack of advance coordination with the airline. According to Aircraft (Security) Rules, 2023, airlines control access to aircraft.

The events raise questions about protocols governing such access and responsibility for coordination between law-enforcement agencies, airport security, and the airline.

INBRIEF



Detained lawyers released after Bar bodies intervene

A group of lawyers was released on Saturday after being detained for nearly two hours while staging a protest outside the Supreme Court, demanding Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar's resignation. The lawyers, who were taken to the Yamuna Sports Complex, were released following interventions by Supreme Court Bar bodies. The Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) and the Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association (SCAORA) passed resolutions addressed to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, seeking the release of the detained lawyers. SCAORA president Devvrat told *The Hindu* that they subsequently received a communication from the CJI's office indicating that the Delhi Police Commissioner had been asked to ensure their immediate release.

Court rejects CJP leader's plea over 'wrongful confinement'

A Delhi court on Saturday dismissed a plea by the head of the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) legal wing Ratna Singh, alleging that she had been "wrongfully confined" by the police outside her residence in Jangpura amid a massive police crackdown in the national capital to thwart a youth protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. Ms. Singh told *The Hindu* that Delhi Police personnel had surrounded the car in which she was sitting outside her residence with advocates Tara Narula and Shivangi Sharma earlier on Saturday. Police personnel had cited "verbal orders from above" to prevent her from leaving, she alleged. Chief Judicial Magistrate Abhinav Pandey of the Saket District Court held that the application was not *prima facie* maintainable in its present form, observing that it failed to comply with the "statutory requirement" of filing an affidavit attesting to the veracity of the allegations, and to specify the exact location of the alleged confinement for determining the court's jurisdiction.

Dilli Haat turns epicentre of protest for a day

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Unable to reach Jantar Mantar because of barricades, hundreds of protesters, mostly unaffiliated with any organisation, began gathering at Dilli Haat, an open-air crafts market, through the AIIMS Metro station on Saturday afternoon.

The shift followed a social media post by All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha Bora declaring that "Dilli Haat is Jantar Mantar for today".

Even as the protesters split into smaller groups and marched near INA Metro station, around the end of the Safdarjung flyover, near INA market, and through adjoining residential colonies, the police chased and detained many of them. By evening, hundreds had gathered near Dilli Haat Metro station, where police personnel were seen grabbing, and putting them into buses. Many protesters wore masks, fearing that revealing their identities could have security and family repercussions.



New location: Hundreds of protesters gathered at Dilli Haat in the city on Saturday.

Protesters from across the city spent hours on Saturday morning trying to reach Jantar Mantar but failed. At 1.10 p.m., the AISA leader announced that the protest had moved to Dilli Haat. Soon after, the police barricaded the Safdarjung flyover as students marched towards the area. During the first two rounds of detentions near the end of the flyover, police personnel were seen wielding lathis. The AISA president and other leaders were subsequently detained, and one protester was seen bleeding profusely from the head.

As the number of students swelled steadily through the day, two recent graduates of Ashoka University said it had taken them around four hours to reach Dilli Haat. One of them, who did not wish to be named, said, "We were unsure whether we would be able to reach Delhi at all today. Following Neha's call, we decided to come here because Jantar Mantar seemed impossible." They said it was a relief that the AIIMS Metro station had not been shut, and that internet services were working.

Groups of students were seen walking along roads, assembling at various points and discussing how their friends were being "brutally detained". Every few minutes, dozens of police personnel were seen running after the groups to disperse and detain them. Many protesters, including women, were dragged away.

Around 4 p.m., those shopping inside Dilli Haat were asked to vacate the premises, and the gates were shut. Women hawkers selling jewellery outside the complex, who were also asked to leave, were angry at the police over their "behaviour with the protesters".

Students were also seen questioning some police personnel about their missing nameplates. The personnel said the nameplates had broken while they were detaining protesters.

INBRIEF



All 22 Indian seafarers safe after attack on oil tanker

Shipping Minister Sarbanada Sonowal has said that Panama-flagged crude oil tanker *MT Gem No. 2*, carrying a crew of 22 Indian nationals, was subjected to a drone attack at Sharjah Anchorage on October 9. Mr. Sonowal, in a post on X, further said that he was relieved to share that all 22 Indian seafarers onboard were reported to be completely safe. "We are continuously monitoring the situation and in contact with the ship management company to ensure security," he added. PTI

Bihar CM transfers ₹1,237 cr. under State pension scheme

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Saturday transferred ₹1,237.48 crore into the bank accounts of over 1.8 crore beneficiaries under the social security pension scheme, which included the elderly, persons with disabilities, and widows. He transferred ₹1,100 per person for September 2026. Congratulating all the beneficiaries, Mr. Choudhary said all District Magistrates must ensure that no eligible beneficiary of the social security pension is left out. He urged public representatives to visit villages to assess disbursement, while adding that increasing the social security pension amount from ₹400 to ₹1,100 has brought a positive change in people's lives.

Former AAP councillor convicted in Delhi riots case

A Delhi court on Saturday convicted former Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) councillor Tahir Hussain of abetment to rioting in a case related to the northeast Delhi riots in 2020. The court acquitted the 12 other accused of all charges. Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh of a Karkardooma court held Tahir Hussain guilty of rioting and abetment, while discharging him of several other offences. The hearing for the sentencing will take place on November 16. Hussain and four others were convicted in July in a case pertaining to the murder of Intelligence Bureau (IB) officer Ankit Sharma during the riots. The northeast Delhi riots of February 2020 claimed 53 lives, left many injured, and resulted in widespread damage to property.

100 senior police officers transferred across J&K

In a major rejig of the Jammu and Kashmir police, Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha on Friday ordered the transfer of 100 senior police officers, including chiefs of several districts. Of them, 28 are Indian Police Service (IPS) officers, while the rest are Jammu and Kashmir Police Service officers. The districts of Ganderbal, Kupwara, Bandipora, Ramban and Poonch, as well as the police districts of Sopore, Handwara and Awantipora, got new chiefs. SSP Traffic, Srinagar City, Aijaz Ahmad Bhat, has been posted as Commandant, 23rd Armed Police while Bisma Qazi will be the new traffic police chief. The L-G also shifted officers of the Railways Police. PTI

SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

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NIA to investigate attack on Indian pilot of flydubai plane

Investigation agency files FIR under anti-hijacking and UAPA laws after Centre says the incident has 'grave national and international ramifications' and the 'larger conspiracy' must be unearthed

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has registered a case in connection with the alleged mid-air hijacking attempt of an Israel-bound flydubai flight and the attack on its Indian pilot Captain Smit Machchhar on September 30.

The agency has invoked Section 3 of the Anti-Hijacking Act and Section 16, read with Section 15(1)(a), of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The first information report (FIR) identifies the accused who attacked Captain Machchhar as the "Omani First Officer of flydubai flight no. 1073".

Recounting the sequence of events, the FIR states that the Omani co-pilot stabbed Captain Machchhar in an apparent attempt to hijack the aircraft or crash it. Mr. Machchhar sustained deep cuts to his head and hands. The incident occurred in the Saudi Arabian airspace near the Jordan-Saudi Arabia border.



Captain Machchhar was airlifted to Abu Dhabi in the United Arab Emirates, where he is recuperating at a hospital. AP

The government referred the matter to the investigation agency for registration of a case and investigation, citing the "grave national and international ramifications" of the attack, and the need to investigate the possible "larger conspiracy." As part of the investigation, the agency may record statements of eyewitnesses, examine any statements made by the accused, and analyse flight data to establish the sequence of events.

The statement of Captain Machchhar might also be recorded. According to information received by the government, the flydubai flight departed from Dubai, UAE at 7.05 a.m. on September 30, carrying 174 passengers and six crew members.

At 9.21 a.m., the airplane reportedly descended rapidly and turned back into the Saudi airspace while flying near the Jordan-Saudi Arabia border. Passengers reported that the first officer stabbed Captain Machchhar but was overpowered and restrained by passengers and crew members.

The other pilots on board subsequently landed the airplane safely at Prince Sultan bin Abdulaziz Airport in Tabuk, northwestern Saudi Arabia, around 10.45 a.m.

The Saudi authorities later arrested the first officer. Captain Machchhar was airlifted to Abu Dhabi in the United Arab Emirates, where he is recuperating at a hospital.

Assam, Meghalaya villagers oppose hydropower project

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

After decades of conflict over a disputed boundary, villagers in Assam and Meghalaya living along the Kulsi river have come together to oppose a hydropower project pursued jointly by the two State governments.

In June 2025, the governments of Assam and Meghalaya announced their plan to build a 55-megawatt hydropower-cum-irrigation project on the Kulsi, a natural habitat of the endangered Gangetic dolphin. The dam was proposed at the confluence of the Dron, Shree and Dilma rivers, which form the Kulsi, a tributary of the Brahmaputra.

The location of the proposed project is on the Assam-Meghalaya border, about 80 km southwest of Guwahati.

On Thursday, more than 2,000 people from the indigenous Bodo, Garo, Khasi and Rabha communities gathered at Ukiam to renew their opposition to the Kulsi project. Ukiam is near the proposed dam site and almost equidistant from Borduar and Langpih, two of the six disputed border sectors awaiting settlement since the 1970s.

Chiefs take a stand

The Assam-Meghalaya Joint Protection Committee (AMJPC), founded in 2025 to coordinate opposition to the proposed project, organised the protest rally. During the rally, three traditional chiefs – Kestor Manik Syiem Iich of Nongkhlaw, Phlowing Syiem Nongbak of Nongmynsaw, and Order Syiem Sad of Rambrai – assured the villagers that they would not grant consent for the hydropower project.

"Projects involving land in Meghalaya require no-objection certificates from the traditional chiefs. Such consent will not be granted for this project," the Nongkhlaw chief said.

On what grounds were large-scale detentions made, ask legal experts

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Amid large-scale detentions across the national capital on Saturday, as police sought to thwart a youth protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over deletions of names from electoral rolls, legal experts questioned the basis on which Delhi Police detained protesters beyond the New Delhi district, where prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) are in force.

The Delhi Police have maintained that detentions in the capital followed violations of prohibitory orders imposed under Section 163 of the BNSS. Section 163 of the BNSS, which replaced Section 144 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), empowers an executive magistrate to issue prohibitory orders where "immediate prevention or speedy remedy is desirable." Late on Saturday evening, police said women protesters and senior citizens were being released from detention centres.



Security personnel keep guard at Cannaught Place in New Delhi on Saturday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

"The detention of CJP representatives from areas in Delhi-NCR where prohibitory orders are not in force is wholly illegal," advocate Nipun Saxena said.

"Intended as an exceptional measure to deal with emergencies and maintain public peace, such orders are often reissued by the authorities in a cyclostyled manner, turning an exceptional power into a routine tool to curb protests," Mr. Saxena added.

Grounds of detention

Referring to instances of protesters being picked up and taken to buses and stadiums across the capital, former Supreme Court judge Abhay S. Oka said authorities were obligated under Article 22 of the Constitution to communicate the grounds for depriving a person of their liberty "as soon as may be". He said this protection could not be circumvented merely by describing the restraint as detention rather than a formal arrest.

Mr. Saxena agreed, saying that even where the police claim to be exercising preventive powers rather than arresting a person for an offence, the grounds for detention must be communicated.

Concerned by 'mass detentions' of Delhi protesters: UN body

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

UN Human Rights Commissioner calls for the immediate release of all those detained arbitrarily

The Office of the United Nations Human Rights Commissioner (OHCHR) on Saturday said it was "concerned" by reports of "mass detentions" at the Delhi protests against the Chief Election Commissioner, a statement that the government rejected.

The UN body said that Indian authorities should ensure that the right to peaceful protest is respected and that all those detained "arbitrarily" must be immediately and unconditionally released. The government responded sharply, calling the concerns "misplaced" and calling the OHCHR's statement "unwarranted interference in the internal affairs of India".

"We are concerned by reports of mass detentions in India of demonstrators, protest leaders, members of civil society organisations, lawyers and journalists, before and during today's large-scale demonstrations in Delhi," UN Human Rights spokesperson Thameen Al-Kheetan said in the statement, adding that any restrictions on the peaceful protests should meet the test of "necessity and proportionality", in a possible reference to the large security presence in the Capital with barricades across central areas, the suspension of the internet, and the cancellation of trains to the city.

"The Indian authorities should also ensure law enforcement forces exercise utmost restraint in response to peaceful protesters, consistent with the country's democratic traditions and human rights obligations," Mr. Al-Kheetan said.

In a statement a few hours later, India's Permanent Mission in Geneva, where the UN body is based, said:

"As in every democracy, Indian citizens exercise this right subject to reasonable restrictions in the interest of public order."

Self-reliance key to future warfare, says Rajnath Singh

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Military power in the future would depend less on the number of platforms a country possesses and more on the speed of sensing, decision-making and action, Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Saturday, while calling for greater self-reliance in defence technology, and stronger partnerships with trusted countries.

Mr. Singh addressed the participants in the second edition of the multinational air exercise 'Tarang Shakti 2026' at the Jodhpur Air Force Station, the Ministry of Defence said in a statement.

Modern warfare was expanding beyond the traditional domains, he told the gathering, adding that drones, artificial intelligence, electronic warfare and long-range precision weapons were increasingly shaping military operations.

Emphasising the importance of *atmanirbharta* (self-reliance) in defence, he said indigenous capabilities were essential to sustain the country during prolonged conflicts.

ED arrests two in drug trafficking syndicate

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested two men in a money-laundering investigation linked to an alleged transnational narcotics trafficking syndicate operated by international drug trafficker Salim Ismail Dola and his associates.

"The accused have been identified as Pravin alias Nagesh Ramchandra Shinde and Brijesh Kanjibhai Moradiya," an official statement said. "They were arrested under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, by the ED's Mumbai Zonal Office," it said.

Elon Musk escalates his attack on Ambani, shares reports on campaign donations for BJP

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Musk said that powerful business interests are blocking Starlink to preserve their dominance

Elon Musk on Saturday stepped up his attack against industrialist Mukesh Ambani, sharing screenshots of media reports alleging that a Reliance-funded firm helped boost BJP campaigns on social media and that a Reliance-lin4ked company made large political donations to the ruling party.

The latest post comes amid Mr. Musk's scathing criticism of Mukesh Ambani over a persistent delay in the launch of Starlink satellite broadband services in India.

Reliance has not publicly responded to Mr. Musk's allegations, while the government has maintained that the country's authorisation framework for telecom and satellite services is "fair and non-discriminatory."

A few hours before he made the post, Mr. Musk wrote on X, "Dear Prime Minister Ambani, Please accept my humble apologies for not realising that you are the real boss of India. Naturally, you would prefer to maintain your monopolistic exploitation of the great people of India, but would you nonetheless consider allowing Starlink to compete?"

On Friday, Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia asserted that India does not permit monopolies in any sector, and that despite the buzz around one particular company, three players – Mr. Musk's Starlink, Reliance Jio's satellite venture Jio Satcom, Bharti-backed Eutelsat OneWeb – have received satcom licences and can start operations after meeting the security requirements and milestones.

Pak. should refrain from 'homilies' at the UN, says India

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

India criticised Pakistan at the UN, saying it was "regrettable" that Islamabad continued to abuse the platform of the world body by peddling lies and falsehoods about the Indian Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir.

India exercised its Right of Reply in response to a statement by Pakistan in the Fourth Committee of the UN General Assembly (UNGA) on Friday, on the agenda item "Decolonization." The committee deals with special political and decolonisation issues.

"It is regrettable that Pakistan continues to abuse this august forum by peddling lies and falsehoods about the Indian Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir," Mahima Kumari Mewar, Member of Parliament, said.

Delivering India's Right of Reply, Ms. Mewar said a country like Pakistan, with an "established" record of military dictatorship, sham elections, incarceration of popularly elected leaders, religious extremism and the sponsoring of terrorism as an instrument of state policy, should in future refrain from "preaching homilies" at the platform. "Jammu and Kashmir is and will always remain an integral and inalienable part of India," she said.



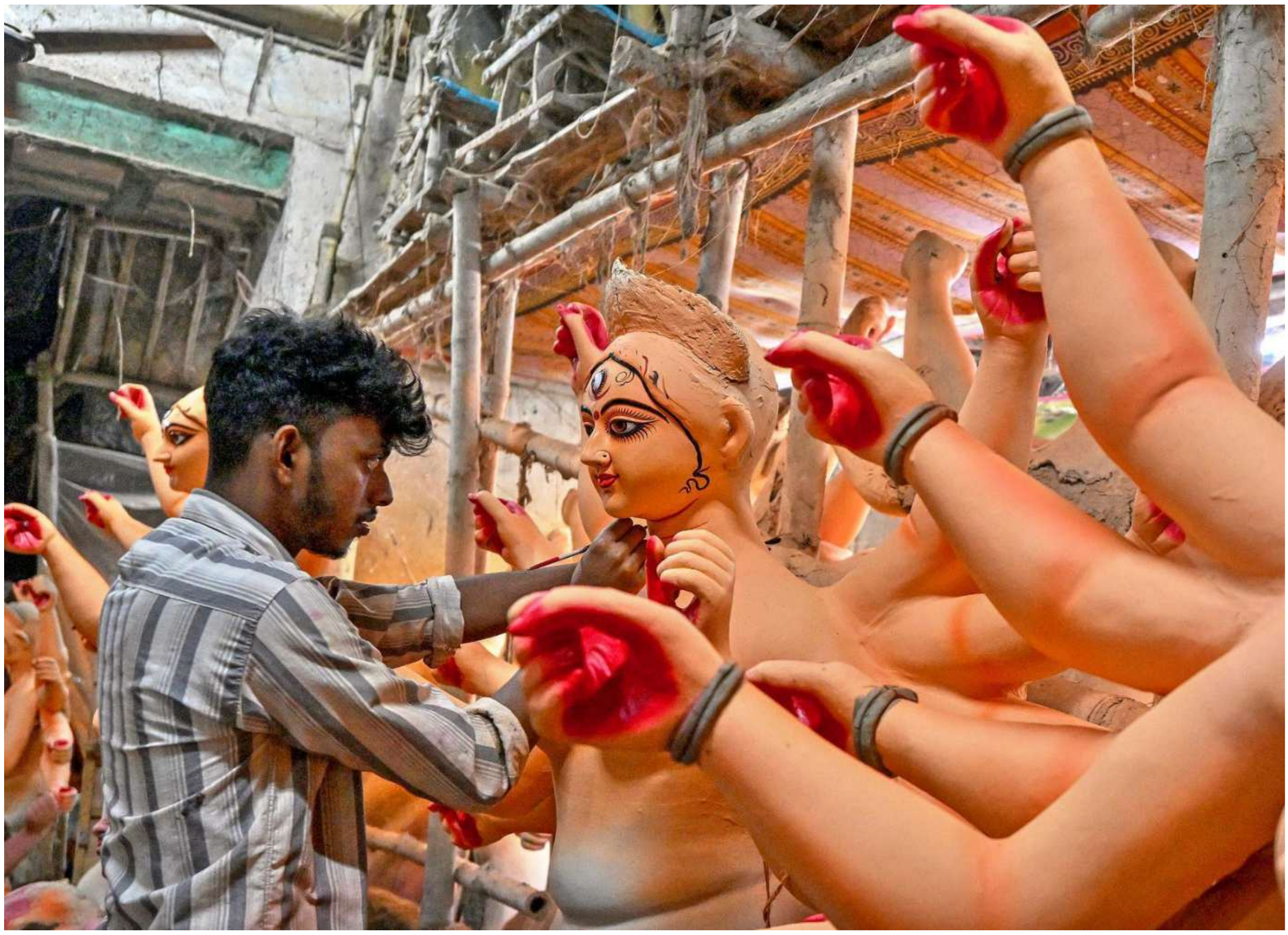
Work in progress: Ahead of Durga Puja, artisans perfect clay idols of Goddess Durga, Lord Ganesh and other deities at Kumartuli in Kolkata.



Basic coat: An artisan sprays paint on a clay idol at Kumartuli, where few women have broken barriers to enter the traditionally male-dominated craft.



Divine details: Idols cost between ₹50,000 and ₹3 lakh, depending on their size, with eco-friendly colours adding to the making charge.



Expert strokes: While some workshops retain the traditional *shabeki* style, others experiment with contemporary designs to meet specific commissions.

Kumartuli: where clay comes alive

In the historic lanes of Kolkata's potters' quarter, majestic idols of Goddess Durga come alive this Puja season as tourists, photographers and social media enthusiasts throng the open-air workshops to witness the meticulous craftsmanship behind the art



K.R. Deepak
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In Kolkata's famed potters' quarter Kumartuli, the rhythm of Durga Puja takes shape in clay. Weeks ahead of the festival, artisans work long hours in cramped workshops, transforming bundles of straw, layers of clay and bamboo frames into majestic idols of Goddess Durga. With remarkable skill and patience, they mould the clay, shape the figures, refine the facial features and carefully paint the idols, gradually bringing the idols to life before they are carried to *puja pandals* across Kolkata and beyond.

Kumartuli's history dates back nearly 300 years and is closely linked to Krishnanagar, in West Bengal's Nadia district. Maharaja Krishnachandra of Krishnanagar is credited with popularising idol worship, with the first Durga Puja believed to have been celebrated there in 1606. Over time, potters from the area migrated to the city, settling along the Hooghly River.

While some workshops retain the traditional *shabeki* style, others experiment with contemporary designs. Idols made for community *pandals* and household *pujas* cost between ₹50,000 and ₹3 lakh, depending on their size, with eco-friendly colours adding to the price. Few women have broken barriers to enter the traditionally male-dominated craft in Kumartuli.

As the festival approaches, the narrow lanes fill with bloggers, photographers, social media influencers and tourists documenting the artisans at work. The crowds reflect how the age-old craft now intersects with tourism and social media, offering visitors a glimpse of Durga Puja preparations and the painstaking craftsmanship behind one of Kolkata's most celebrated festivals.



Celestial celebrities: With precision and patience, artisans mould, shape and paint the clay idols before they are carried to *puja pandals* across Kolkata and beyond.



Moulded by time: For many artisan families, idol-making is a generations-old tradition, with Durga Puja believed to have been first celebrated in Krishnanagar, Nadia district, in 1606.



Festive flair: One of Kolkata's most celebrated festivals, Durga Puja brings communities together in a celebration of faith while providing a livelihood for many.



Young fans: Visitors take selfies and pose for photographs beside unfinished idols of Goddess Durga at Kumartuli.



Form to faith: Artisans breathe life into the clay idols that will soon grace *puja pandals* and move devotees.



Decked to impress: People crowd around to photograph an idol of Goddess Durga as it is readied for transport from Kumartuli.

CMYK

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Why was IceCube founder given the physics Nobel?

What is the IceCube in Antarctica? How did Francis Halzen help build it? And why are scientists 'catching' neutrinos?

Vasudevan Mukunth

The story so far:

The Belgian-American physicist Francis Halzen has won the physics Nobel Prize for 2026 for helping build the IceCube observatory in Antarctica. IceCube uses thousands of sensors buried deep in the ice to detect subatomic particles called neutrinos.

What are neutrinos?

Since the early 20th century, scientists have known that energetic particles called cosmic rays constantly bombard the earth from outer space. Most cosmic rays are protons or the nuclei of elements like helium and iron. Some of these particles have been found to have more energy than the world's largest particle accelerator – the Large Hadron Collider (LHC) in Europe – has managed.

Scientists thought powerful events like exploding stars or jets of energy emitted by distant galaxies could have given these particles a Herculean push, but they couldn't know for sure. Just looking in the direction a cosmic ray came from didn't help. Since cosmic rays are charged particles, they could have been deflected by magnetic fields in space before reaching earth.

So they turned to neutrinos. These subatomic particles have no electric charge, a very small mass, and interact very rarely with matter. Nuclear reactions, like fusion in the sun's belly, produce neutrinos in copious numbers. Trillions of them pass through your body every second without leaving any trace. And they travel in a straight line through space.

> Of the lakh or so neutrinos IceCube registers every year above an energy cutoff, around a hundred come from astrophysical sources in outer space

How do you catch a neutrino?

Halzen and others came up with the idea of IceCube to 'catch' and study neutrinos with very high energy. When a cosmic-ray proton strikes other atoms, it can produce particles called pions, which rapidly decay through reactions that could produce neutrinos. These high-energy neutrinos are an indication that some high-energy event produced them.

Since neutrinos interact rarely with matter, one can detect more neutrinos using more matter. The IceCube observatory uses the enormous volume of water ice in Antarctica, which scientists have embedded with some 5,100 sensors.

Halzen and John G. Learned proposed this concept in 1987-1988. Halzen went on to organise the effort, funded primarily by the U.S. National Science Foundation. The award committee said Halzen was feted for proposing the idea and for keeping hundreds of scientists and engineers working on it for decades.

How does IceCube work?

IceCube took its full shape in 2011 following seven years of construction. (Famously, experts dug holes in the ice to place the sensors not using shovels but by shooting jets of hot water, then lowering sensors suspended on cables fast enough before the ice froze again.)

Today, IceCube includes 5,160 optical sensors on 86 cables, lying 1.4 km to 2.4 km underground, encompassing roughly a cubic kilometre of ice. Each sensor has a device that converts the faint light from a collision into an electric signal and records it. The collective data flows to computers on the surface and then to researchers around the world.

When an energetic neutrino strikes an atom's nucleus inside the ice, the event creates charged particles that streak through the surrounding ice. Some of them even move faster than light can in that material, causing them to emit Cherenkov radiation, visible as a dull blue glow. The sensors look for and record this emission.

Different kinds of neutrino interactions produce different kinds of particles that outrun light. Taking this together with which sensors recorded the glow and in what order, IceCube researchers piece together the neutrino's energy and direction. Of the lakh or so neutrinos IceCube registers every year above an energy cutoff, around a hundred come from astrophysical sources in outer space.

What has IceCube found?

In 2013, scientists identified two neutrinos with around 140 times the energy of a proton accelerated by the LHC. With more data and analysis, the collaboration established that a population of high-energy neutrinos was coming to our planet from elsewhere in the universe – and that IceCube could spot them. It was a landmark event in neutrino astronomy.

In 2017, IceCube found an energetic neutrino coming from a distant galaxy, whose black hole was also powering a jet of radiation pointed roughly at the earth. In 2022, the instrument found more neutrinos than expected coming from NGC 1068, a galaxy 46 million lightyears away, also with an active central black hole.

IceCube scientists are still working on the sources of the universe's most energetic neutrinos and how neutrino-catching events can be correlated with data from other telescopes.

What was the Chemistry Nobel Prize given for?

What are chirality and molecular 'handedness', and why does life favour one form over the other? Why does the handedness of a molecule matter when developing drugs? What did Henri Kagan and Kenso Soai discover? Can it explain the origins of life?

Jacob Koshy

The story so far:

The 2026 Nobel Prize in Chemistry has been awarded to Henri Kagan and Kenso Soai for showing that it is possible to amplify a molecule's "handedness" and direct it in a way that it can be used to produce pharmaceutical products of a very high purity. Their work also offers clues to explaining how life on earth could have evolved from simple molecules.

What are chirality and "handedness"?

Your left and right hand have the same number of fingers. Both have ring fingers and thumbs of the same length. Yet why can't you wear the left hand's glove on the right? The reason is 'chirality,' from the Greek word *kheir*, which means hand. It is the geometric property of an object or molecule that makes it non-superimposable on its mirror image.

Many chemical molecules that make up substances also possess this property of chirality. The mirror images of a molecule – the left glove and right glove so to say – are called enantiomers. Yet the organic molecules that make up living organisms are overwhelmingly either left-handed or right-handed, rather than occurring in 50:50 proportions. This property, of homochirality, is as if a fashion house decided to base its entire business on making only left-handed gloves and accessories to match. Or, as we observe in daily life, most people are right-handed, and urban fixtures such as door-knobs seem designed with them in mind.

Every amino acid, the building blocks of protein, comes in the "left" (L) form and every sugar in your DNA the "right" (D) form. What is the puzzle? It is that ordinary laboratory reactions, though, often produce equal amounts of both enantiomers – a 50:50 mix known as a racemate. The French chemist Louis Pasteur observed this as far back as 1848, when bacteria devoured one mirror form of tartaric acid and left the other untouched.

> This was the first time anyone had made a one-handed product from non-chiral ingredients in this way, and the reaction remains the only known example of its kind



Japanese Nobel laureate Kenso Soai at a press conference in Tokyo. AFP

Why does chirality matter to the pharmaceutical industry?

A drug works by attaching to the surface of enzymes or receptors – just like a password is required for a lock. In the world of enantiomers, the same letters of the password in the wrong order can at best be harmless and at worst be harmful – repeatedly entering the wrong password can lock you out of a system.

The drug thalidomide offers a cautionary tale. First marketed as a sedative, it left thousands of children with birth defects in the early 1960s. For a long time, these defects were attributed to the presence of both enantiomers. However, subsequent analysis says that is only part of the explanation. The broader principle is that enantiomers matter.

Ethambutol, a first-line tuberculosis drug, is another example. Its (S,S) form is about 500 times more potent against the tuberculosis bacillus than its (R,R) mirror image. Yet optic-nerve damage, a serious side effect of the drug, is associated with dose and duration of treatment. Producing a purer form of the more potent enantiomer could therefore allow lower doses, potentially reducing patients' exposure to the drug and its side effects. The challenge is how to manufacture the desired enantiomer with sufficient purity.

What was Frank's model and how was it tested?

In 1953, Charles Frank, a theoretical physicist at the University of Bristol, used mathematics to analyse why the molecules of life acquired their bias towards one handedness. His model needed three things: a substance that catalyses its own production (autocatalysis); a catalyst that favours one hand (enantioselective catalysis); and an "anti-catalyst" that suppresses its mirror image. Combine them and even a tiny initial difference, where one form is present slightly more than the other, snowballs exponentially. It took decades. Autocatalysis was already known. Asymmetric, or enantioselective catalysis, had already earned Nobel Prizes in 2001 and 2021. What nobody had shown was mutual antagonism, or the marriage of autocatalysis and asymmetry, and this was where Kagan, in 1986, and Soai, in 1995, made their contribution.

What did each laureate do, and what set them apart?

Kagan, then at Paris-Sud, challenged a dogma. Chemists believed that for more product purity, more of a catalyst's chiral ingredient had to be proportionally pure. Therefore the race was for ever purer ingredients. Kagan asked what the metal in a catalyst actually does, and reasoned that it grips not one but two chiral molecules (the "ligands" that give the catalyst its handedness). Suppose you build the catalyst from a mix of the two enantiomers – say 75% right-handed and 25% left-handed – the metal picks its two partners at random, so three kinds of catalyst form: right-right (about 56%), left-left (about 6%) and a mixed right-left pair (about 38%). The two matched pairs work well. The mixed pair barely works at all, so it sits idle and takes its share of both hands out of play. Because the minority hand mostly ends up paired with a majority-hand partner in an idle mixed complex, left-left catalysts are rare, and the reaction is driven almost entirely by right-right ones. The product comes out roughly 90:10 in favour of the right hand, purer than the 75:25 mix you started with.

This overturned the old assumption that a product could be no purer than the catalyst's ingredients. Kagan's distinction was therefore twofold. He found a new rule – that purity can be amplified and he also gave chemists a diagnostic to determine how many ligands a catalyst could hold and which forms do the work. Soai's contribution was to build the reaction Frank had imagined: a molecule that makes more of itself, and in the process makes itself purer. In his reaction, the product is also the catalyst. Each batch of product is added to the next batch as catalyst, and each round comes out more lopsided than the last. Starting from a pyrimidyl alcohol with a 5% excess of one hand, five rounds lifted it to 90%. In a later version, an excess of just 0.00005%, far too small to measure by ordinary means, became more than 99.5% pure in three rounds. That is an amplification of roughly 6,30,000-fold. Then came the decisive step. Soai showed that no chiral starting point is needed. Begin with ingredients that have no handedness at all, and the reaction ends up almost entirely one-handed over repeated runs, with the hand chosen by chance. This was the first time anyone had made a one-handed product from non-chiral ingredients in this way, and the reaction remains the only known example of its kind.

Is this a model for the evolution of life?

Not quite, and the Nobel Committee itself says so. Frank's model is one possible explanation for how life acquired its molecular handedness 3.5 billion to 4 billion years ago, an event we may never fully understand. Soai's reaction uses zinc reagents in an organic solvent, nothing like the watery "prebiotic soup" in which life is thought to have emerged. The Nobel Committee calls it a "proof of concept".

Kagan and Soai showed that the mechanisms Frank envisaged could work in the lab. Had Frank lived, he might have shared in the prize.

What made optogenetics research Nobel-worthy?

What is optogenetics and how does it help us understand our brain? What did the three Nobel laureates in in Physiology or Medicine discover? What makes their collaboration special? What is the future of optogenetics?

Ramya Kannan

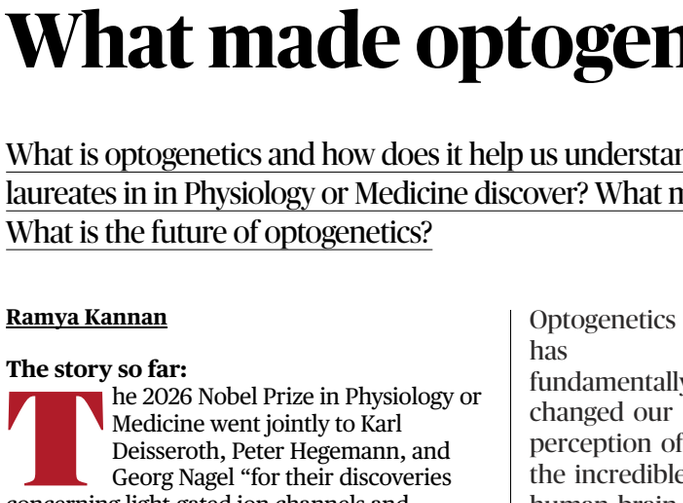
The story so far:

The 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine went jointly to Karl Deisseroth, Peter Hegemann, and Georg Nagel "for their discoveries concerning light-gated ion channels and optogenetics." The prize amount of 12 million Swedish kronor will be shared equally by them.

What is optogenetics?

How the brain executes its functions, communicates with the body to get it to do things, such as moderate feelings, behaviour, and regular bodily functions, has long been a mystery. It was only in the 20th century that researchers began to map areas of the brain to their functions, but these methods could not prove any causal relationships. So, in effect, the image they developed of the brain was rudimentary – like a sketch map, full of question marks and unknowns, as the Nobel committee described it. Now all this is changing, thanks to revolutionary techniques including optogenetics, a method that makes it possible to show how nerve cells in the brain shape memories, feelings and behaviour. Commenting on this year's choice for the award, Per Svenningsson, Chair of the Nobel Committee for Physiology or Medicine, said: "Optogenetics provides opportunities for mapping the brain in a way that we could once only dream of".

> Optogenetics has fundamentally changed our perception of the incredible human brain and its functions



The announcement of the winners of the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine at the Karolinska Institute in Stockholm, Sweden. AFP

What have researchers done with optogenetics?

Deisseroth and colleagues coined the portmanteau word *opto*, from optics, meaning the use of light or optical technology, and genetics, referring to the use of genetic engineering, as their revolutionary technique involved both these fields. The word first appeared in print in late 2006, in a review article published in the *Journal of Neuroscience* and was defined as the fusion of "genetic targeting and optical control in neural circuits."

Using optogenetics, researchers have since been able to reveal the neural circuits that govern specific memories, feelings, and behaviours relevant for neurological and psychiatric disorders including Alzheimer's, dementia, addiction, and depression. In clinical medicine, researchers are using the method in attempts to restore sight in people with visual impairment. They use harmless viral agents to deliver genes encoding light-sensitive proteins into specific target cells, then activate these proteins with precise pulses of light to study patterns of neural activity.

What did the three Laureates do?

The 2026 Nobel laureates for Medicine pipped many bookies' favourites, including GLP-1 class of drugs and CART-T, to emerge winners. As per the Nobel Committee's release, the journey began with Hegemann's curiosity, as he wondered how Chlamydomonas, a single-celled alga, was able to swim towards a light source. Fellow countryman and scientist Nagel went on to discover channelrhodopsin, an algal protein with unique properties, found on the surface of the cell. When it is illuminated by blue light, a channel opens through the protein. Charged ions then flow into the cell, creating an electrical impulse that researchers can track. It required the American Deisseroth to transform the protein into a light-controlled switch for nerve cells. In the 2000s, Hegemann and Deisseroth introduced the gene for channelrhodopsin into nerve cells from rats. By illuminating the cells with blue light, they were able to trigger a nerve signal. Deisseroth published this breakthrough in 2005. Two years later, he made this light-controlled switch for nerve cells to work in the brains of living mice.

The whole process might be understood in three stages. Firstly, scientists use harmless viral vectors to deliver genes for light-sensitive proteins – called opsins (such as channelrhodopsin from algae) – into specific target cells. Once the cells express these proteins on their membranes, researchers deliver precise pulses of light using tiny fiber-optic cables or LEDs. Finally, depending on type of opsin used, light exposure either opens ion channels to excite and activate the cell (turning it "on") or pumps ions to inhibit and silence it (turning it "off").

What makes their collaboration special?

Breakthrough scientific discoveries seldom come without collaborations, often across continents. This one spanned America and Europe. Deisseroth, who graduated from Harvard, is an American neuroscientist and physician based at Stanford University and the Howard Hughes Medical Institute. Videos of Deisseroth sharing the news that he had been awarded the Nobel with his children went viral on social media. Hegemann is a German biophysicist based at the Humboldt University of Berlin and Nagel is a German biophysicist based at the University of Würzburg.

What is the future of optogenetics?

Optogenetics has fundamentally changed our perception of the incredible human brain and its functions. Every window into the brain helps advance our knowledge a little more. Beyond the wonder of science itself, nations now need to make sure that such cutting-edge research makes its speedy way from the lab to the field, benefiting all citizens who may require such interventions. While a better understanding of how the brain functions has obvious advantages for healthcare, technologies such as optogenetics could also help address conditions that affect older people.

The jurist and a redemption

Navi Pillay

The Nobel Peace Prize for 2026 is as much a recognition of the South African jurist's lifelong commitment to justice for the oppressed and the powerless as it is a rebuke to the idea that might is right

Srinivasan Ramani

In awarding Navanethem 'Navi' Pillay the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize, the Norwegian Nobel Committee recognised a jurist whose long career qualifies her as one of the most deserving recipients in the Prize's 125-year history.

Ms. Pillay was born in 1941 in a poor neighbourhood of Durban in a Tamil family. Her grandparents had been brought from India in the 1890s as indentured labourers for Natal province's sugar plantations. Her father was a bus driver. After studying law at the University of Natal, she became the first woman to open a law practice in the province in 1967. She defended opponents of apartheid and fought for political prisoners.

In 1973, she won the inmates of Robben Island, who included Nelson Mandela, the right to legal representation. Later, she earned a doctorate in law from Harvard and campaigned for the equality clause in South Africa's post-apartheid Constitution.

In 1995, she was nominated by President Mandela to serve on the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda. She spent eight years on the tribunal, four as president. It delivered two landmark rulings. One, rape and sexual violence could constitute genocide (the 'Akayesu case'). Two, those who spread hate propaganda against the Tutsis by radio and print were guilty of incitement to genocide (the 'Media case'). Following this stint, she served terms as a judge of the International Criminal Court (2003-08), as UN High Commissioner for Human Rights (2008-14) and recently as the chair of the UN Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory from 2021 to 2025. She also sits as judge ad hoc, designated by The Gambia, in the International Court of Justice's genocide case against Myanmar today.

A stark contrast

The decision by the Committee cannot be seen in isolation from what it did a year ago. In its statement lauding the work of Ms. Pillay, it said "peace requires justice" and that international law "is no longer just a supplement to peace and security. It is an absolute necessity". It warned of "a shift towards power politics at the expense of legal frameworks" and of a world where "might overtakes right" and of judges who are "sanctioned" while their institutions are "attacked". It said that cases under international law have "produced different results depending on who is the perpetrator and who is the victim".

Between the lines, it is clear whom the Committee is referring to. The U.S. under Donald Trump has sanctioned ICC officials since 2025 - and has reportedly expanded them on the same day the Nobel Peace Prize was awarded to Ms. Pillay. In January 2026, U.S. forces abducted Venezuela's President Nicolas Maduro and took control over the country's oil resources and revenues. On February 28, the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran, killing its Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. U.S. forces struck a primary school in Minab in southern Iran, killing more than 160 schoolgirls. The war that followed has led to a global fuel crisis and has still not ended.

Last year, the Committee honoured Venezuelan Opposition leader Maria Corina Machado, a staunch ally of the U.S. and Israel, and who backed the U.S. military pressure and actions on her country. In January, Ms. Machado farcically "gifted" her medal to Mr. Trump at the White House, embarrassing the Committee which said the prize could not be transferred. The symbolism was clear though – the recipient of the award was handing it over to a man presiding over severe breaches of international law, which the Committee has now mentioned without naming Mr. Trump.

Justice over might

The choice of Ms. Pillay could help the Committee fend off some of the criticisms it faced in the past. In Plato's Republic, Thrasymachus insisted that justice is nothing but the advantage of the stronger, which has now been turned into doctrine by great powers. The Committee's statement is telling in this regard. It recalls that the "key insight" of the post-Second World War order was that lasting peace "must be built on legal principles, not on the will of the strong or a fragile balance of power". In honouring Ms. Pillay, the Committee has in effect, rejected the Thrasymachian doctrine that has been adopted by leaders like Mr. Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and endorsed the conviction of jurists like her that law and not might must govern relations between nations.

ILLUSTRATION: R. RAJESH



In September 2025, Ms. Pillay was the chair of the UN commission of inquiry, which concluded that Israel has committed genocide against Palestinians in Gaza and found reasonable grounds that four of the five acts listed in the 1948 Genocide Convention had been committed since October 2023. Explaining the finding, she wrote in the *New York Times*: "The judicial panel over which I presided convicted three Rwandans of genocide. So I understand the word 'genocide', and it is not one I use lightly". Citing words by then Israeli Defence Minister Yoav Gallant and President Isaac Herzog, she said: "Their words have been matched by deeds... and a siege we concluded was designed to starve the population to death". And that those deeds were "not the accidents of war. They are acts calculated to bring about the destruction of a people". While saying so, she did not ignore the Hamas atrocities of October 7, which her Commission documented, adding: "But no crime, however grave, justifies genocide".

Predictably, the reaction to the Prize from Mr. Trump and Israel has been angry. Mr. Trump went on a rant on how he deserved the award and insulted Ms. Pillay while Israel called the award a "grotesque weaponisation" of the prize. The Committee's chair, when asked about Ms. Pillay's Commission terming Israel's actions as genocide, said the "Nobel Committee is not the court", but the Committee did send a message by honouring the jurist who named the crimes.

Threats to peace

World peace is threatened today in two directions. From the developed world, a superpower is using military superiority to nakedly grab resources while seeking to dismantle institutions meant to restrain such conduct. In the Global South, regimes such as the Myanmar junta have waged unremitting violence against the country's citizens, including the expulsion of lakhs of Rohingya since 2017, with scarcely a world response. Both actions stem from a faith in power and in "might being right", cocking a snook at an international order painstakingly built since 1945 but limited by the self-seeking actions of the great powers.

In such a milieu, it has fallen to jurists of international courts and investigators of human rights bodies to rise to the occasion to name illegal acts accurately and to sensitise the world to them, even if their findings are not binding or their judgments go unenforced. The Committee describes judges as "those who guard the thin red line between order and chaos" and in recognising Ms. Pillay, it has honoured their wider work. In doing so, it has also rightly offered a corrective against itself.

THE GIST

- In apartheid South Africa, Navi Pillay defended opponents of the regime and fought for political prisoners, including Nelson Mandela
- In 1995, she was nominated by President Mandela to serve on the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda
- She also served as an ICC judge, UN High Commissioner for Human Rights and, most recently, chair of the UN Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory

Flight from boredom

Anne Carson

Moving seamlessly between the ancient and the contemporary, the Canadian writer's works blur the boundaries between scholarship, poetry, and prose

Radhika Santhanam

In *Plainwater* (1995), the Canadian poet and classicist Anne Carson writes, "I will do anything to avoid boredom. It's the task of a lifetime." Asked once in an interview with *Brick, A Literary Journal* why she fears boredom so much, she replied, "Largely because it's the condition next to death."

Carson, 76, has spent a lifetime resisting intellectual stillness and literary categories. Drawing on Greek classics and mythology, she straddles the worlds of poetry, scholarship, and prose, creating works that occupy the unexplored, unnamed spaces between genres. The Swedish Academy, while awarding her the 2026 Nobel Prize in Literature, said, "Almost all her literary production has centred upon the intersection between the philologist's obsession with words and the poet's desire for new meaning."

Born in Toronto in 1950, Carson discovered Sappho at 15, when she came across a bilingual edition of the ancient Greek poet at a shopping mall. A year later, her high-school Latin teacher, recognising her interest, offered to teach her Greek during lunch breaks.

Her passion led to a PhD in classics at the University of Toronto. Over the years, she taught classics, comparative literature, and poetry at universities across the U.S. and Canada. She has called Homer her greatest literary inspiration. Once, when asked which book published that year she had most enjoyed, she replied that she hadn't read any: "Mostly the books I read are published in 500 BC."

ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR



Carson's first book, *Eros the Bittersweet* (1986), grew out of her doctoral research on Sappho. It examines desire as stemming as much from longing as from lack. With this book, she began to carve out a distinctive space between classical scholarship and literary imagination.

In 1998, Carson published what arguably remains her best-known and most accessible work, *Autobiography of Red*. Reimagining the ancient Greek myth of Geryon and Herakles as a queer coming-of-age story, it combines poetry and prose to explore desire, vulnerability, and identity.

A life in fragments

Carson did not initially set out to become a poet. "I preferred drawing, but wasn't very good at it," she told *The Guardian*.

Her first book of poetry, *Short Talks* (1992), in fact began as drawings. She added titles, which grew longer, and eventually the drawings disappeared altogether. What was left was a series of brief prose poems, each exploring a subject – from Van Gogh to orchids to walking backwards – through unexpected observations.

In her first essay in *Men in the Off Hours* (2000), a collection of short poems, translations from ancient Greek and Latin, epitaphs, interviews, and other forms, she uses Thucydides and Virginia Woolf to talk about time, an example of her use of strange juxtapositions. It was when she was writing this collection that her mother died, becoming the subject of the closing piece in the book. Asked once by the Louisiana Channel about writing about people in her own life, Carson said she was appalled by it. "I am determined not to do that, but you have no other understanding of reality except the one you've lived. I don't have imagination and cannot make up stories."

In 2001, she published *The Beauty of the Husband*, a semi-autobiographical work of narrative verse about the painful collapse of a marriage. In it, the speaker says her husband spitefully grabbed her books and took them away after their marriage ended; Carson later revealed that her own husband did the same, but returned them later. It won her the T.S. Eliot Prize, making her the first woman to receive the award.

Carson has always guarded her personal life, except when she published an essay in *The London Review of Books* announcing that she suffers from Parkinson's disease and bemoaning that it had affected her handwriting. When the Swedish Academy contacted her, she said she had been avoiding phone calls from everyone and was planning to go for a walk in the forest with her husband in Iceland, where she also holds citizenship.

The game changer

Harmanpreet Kaur

The cricketer who helped popularise women's cricket in India has stepped down as captain but will continue to play for the national team

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Dressed in a dark blue blazer and white trousers, her hair gathered in a tight ponytail and her hands clasped behind her back, Harmanpreet Kaur is looking at the famous balcony at Lord's. The camera has captured the moment from behind, as she stands there on cricket's best-known venue, situated in northwest London.

The picture seems to have been taken in July, during the photoshoot ahead of the historic Women's Test match between India and England. It was the first ever women's Test at Lord's, the history of which dates back 239 years. Harmanpreet chose that image for the Instagram post through which she announced her decision to step down as the India captain. Harmanpreet's fairly long and well-written message was posted on Tuesday. It has had 1.4 million views and about 30,500 comments.

Not everyone who viewed the photograph in the post would have been a long-time follower of women's cricket. It is not even a decade since female practitioners of India's favourite obsession began to be known beyond their families and friends, apart from a small circle of committed supporters.

ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR



And it was Harmanpreet who forced the Indian cricket fan to take a closer look at the women's game. In the semifinal of the 2017 World Cup at Derby, she played an innings that still remains perhaps the greatest played by a woman. Her 171 not out off just 115 balls stunned defending champions Australia. Former Australian captain Alyssa Healy said it even forced her team to change the way it played its cricket.

Innings of a lifetime

Harmanpreet's own hero, Virender Sehwag, called it an innings of a lifetime and tweeted "Harmanpreet Kaur...Fan!" When she was a little girl growing up in Punjab's Moga wanting to be a cricketer, when hardly anyone there knew women even played the game, she used to be teased by her brother, "What will you do – open with Sehwag?"

Two years after that out-of-the-world knock, Harmanpreet had told this writer, during an interview in Surat, how much she used to wish for people to come and watch women play cricket. She was grateful destiny chose her to play a part in making it possible.

Harmanpreet was the catalyst, but it was the BCCI's decision to take women's cricket under its wings that brought visibility and professionalism to the game. Then the launch of the Women's Premier League (WPL), in 2023, and India's victory at the ODI World Cup at home last year have expanded the fan base. Harmanpreet was the captain who led India to that World Cup win; it was India's first global trophy in women's cricket. She was also the skipper when Mumbai Indians emerged as the WPL champion in the inaugural edition.

She has had a lot of success in recent times, too. Under her captaincy, India won the Asia Cup and then the gold medal at the Asian Games. Before that, India crushed England in that Test match at Lord's. That was only her fifth Test as captain. That women get to play very few matches in the game's finest format remains a cause for concern even in these rosy times. She led India in 51 One-Day Internationals and 155 Twenty20 Internationals.

Overall, she has played eight Tests, 164 ODIs and 210 T20Is. Those numbers could grow further, as she has clearly said she wants to continue to play for India, though she has resigned as captain. She has plenty to offer as a player, and India needs her in the line-up. She remains one of the best batters in the game. Few women could hit a cricket ball as hard as she could. Her ability to hit hard was noticed early. And she had worked hard on that. Her first coach Yadwinder Singh made her hit 100 to 150 sixes every day. She debuted for India in 2009. Three years later, she led the country for the first time at the Asia Cup in 2012 – it would take a few years before she was made captain full-time – and India emerged as champions. She went on to lead India in many more memorable wins.

As she looked at the Lord's balcony that sunny day in July, in the twilight of her career, some of those images may have passed through her mind.

Scientists report world's first working nuclear clocks

Vasudevan Mukunth

Atomic clocks are the world's gold standard for timekeeping, at the heart of everything from GPS navigation to synchronised networks. A ytterbium atomic clock is so precise it misses one second every 23 billion years.

Yet scientists are interested in more precise clocks to detect infinitesimal changes in fundamental forces and further advance navigation.

In two papers in *Nature*, scientists from Europe and China have now reported the world's first working nuclear clocks.

In an atomic clock, an atom's electrons are easily disturbed by electric or magnetic fields and temperature changes in a room, but the nucleus is shielded by the electron cloud. Exciting a nucleus usually requires energetic X-rays or gamma rays, which are difficult to harness. However, the thorium-229 isotope's nucleus has a transition energy low enough to be triggered by an ultraviolet laser.

A laser's electric field oscillates rapidly: positive, zero, negative, zero, positive, and so on.

The laser's frequency can drift slightly, however. In a nuclear clock, scientists expose thorium-229 nuclei to the laser and check how readily they become excited. If it happens less often than expected, the laser's frequency has drifted away and a computer corrects it.

In one study, teams from Beijing and Shanghai embedded thorium-229 in calcium fluoride crystals and fired an ultraviolet laser at them. A feedback loop constantly checked the laser against the thorium nuclei and corrected it.

The second effort, by teams from Austria and Germany, built a thorium-229 clock and used it to look for dark matter.

The thorium-229 nucleus has such low transition energy because the strong nuclear force and the electromagnetic force nearly cancel each other out. Thus, the nuclear clock is highly sensitive to any slight changes in these fundamental forces.

Some theories suggest ultralight dark matter may cause these constants to fluctuate as it passes through earth. The team ran the nuclear clock alongside a ytterbium atomic clock. Because the two clocks react differently to fluctuating physics constants, any change in their relative tick rates could reveal the presence of dark matter. The teams didn't find a signal, however.

These prototypes are not yet as precise as the best atomic clocks but their architecture is proven. With upgrades to laser power and crystal quality, scientists expect nuclear clocks to eventually surpass their atomic predecessors.

T.N. may encounter El Niño differently from rest of India

In strong El Niño years, pressure differences between the Bay of Bengal and the Arabian Sea can drive moist air into coastal Tamil Nadu; warmer Bay waters boost evaporation, while Nov.-Dec. cyclonic circulations trigger intense, localised rainfall

R. Venkatesan

The El Niño Southern Oscillation is a climate phenomenon in the Pacific Ocean that happens every two to seven years. Its effects, however, are global.

This year, weather agencies worldwide are tracking a supposed 'super' El Niño. It refers to surface waters of the Pacific Ocean off the western coast of Peru and Ecuador becoming warmer than average. Typically, these waters warm by about 0.5 °C, but this year the rise has reached 2 °C – a phenomenon referred to as a 'super' El Niño.

In an El Niño year, India has recorded deficient rainfall and a higher incidence of droughts, on average. However, Tamil Nadu has reported a strikingly different pattern.

In addition to the El Niño, the Indian Ocean has its own climate driver, called the Indian Ocean dipole (IOD). The IOD is a natural phenomenon where the equatorial western Ocean experiences abnormal warming while the equatorial eastern Ocean experiences abnormal cooling.

A positive IOD occurs when the western Ocean near Africa becomes warmer than the eastern Ocean near Indonesia. Recently, the IMD's Northeast Monsoon outlook reported a neutral IOD and forecast normal to above-normal rainfall across southern Tamil Nadu under the prevailing conditions.

(Forecasts are updated when a depression or cyclone develops over the Bay of Bengal and close monitoring becomes essential. Because a cyclone's formation involves nonlinear processes, it is hard to reliably predict its evolution until a cyclone has fully developed.)

When an El Niño shifts global wind and pressure patterns, it can supercharge the northeast monsoon over Tamil Nadu, leading to extreme rainfall and cyclones. For example, the 2015 El Niño was one of the strongest in recent decades. While India faced a weak southwest monsoon, Tamil Nadu was hit by devastating floods. Chennai recorded 1,522 mm of rain in just four days (December 1-4, 2015), more than double the normal.

Studies have found two main reasons for this divergence. First, during strong El Niño years, pressure differences between the Bay of Bengal and the Arabian Sea create a "wind tunnel" effect that drives moist air into coastal Tamil Nadu. Second, when an El Niño coincides with warmer waters in the Bay, evaporation increases. Cyclonic circulations in November-December then release this stored heat as intense, localised rainfall.

The possible impact in October to December 2026? As monsoon winds reverse into the northeasterlies, the El Niño can strengthen moisture inflow from the Bay of Bengal. This has often resulted in frequent and heavy rains and cyclones along the Tamil Nadu coast.

Scientists monitor the El Niño's progress using satellites that measure sea surface temperature, rainfall, and trade winds, and combine the data with that from buoys, boats, deep-water stations, and coastal radars. Together, these readings provide a 3D picture of how the ocean and the atmosphere are changing.

So far, satellite data show unusual warming in the northern Indian Ocean, especially in the southern Bay of Bengal, where sea temperatures have risen by about 1° C as of September 2026. This warming is expected to spread northwards in the coming months. Recent data also show that the entire Indian Ocean is warmer than usual. The only exceptions are the head Bay and the northern Arabian Sea.

Sea currents also have a role to play. Along the Tamil Nadu coast, scientists have found that the East India Coastal Current (EICC) undergoes a seasonal reversal between February and November – a phenomenon unique to this region. Normally, equatorial currents in the western Indian Ocean flow eastwards, but in 2026, a westward flow has been observed, indicating anomalous equatorial forcing.

The EICC's reversal alters alongshore transport and contributes to sea surface temperature variations. And during the northeast monsoon, these circulation shifts and ocean-atmosphere interactions may favour the development of low-pressure systems. When atmospheric depressions interact with such warm oceanic environments, the enhanced heat and moisture supply can allow them to intensify. During El Niño years, winds weaken and skies clear, allowing more sunlight to heat the ocean. In the Bay of Bengal, the shallow mixed layer and salinity stratification trap this heat, warming the waters faster. As ocean temperatures tend upward, these supercharged events are becoming more likely. If we monitor the ocean consistently, we can also spot these events early.

Recently, the EU and Canada announced a real-time ocean data collection effort called 'OceanEye' at the United Nations General Assembly. More such efforts are urgently needed because the ocean remains one of the least-observed parts of the earth system.

(R. Venkatesan is former consultant, UNESCO IOC Paris, and adjunct professor, University of Massachusetts, Dartmouth)

Formidable forecast

An El Niño can supercharge the northeast monsoon over Tamil Nadu, leading to extreme rainfall, cyclones

- Weather agencies are tracking a 'super' El Niño, with the equatorial Pacific Ocean's surface waters warming by 2° C
- While India typically faces severe droughts during an El Niño, Tamil Nadu often experiences extreme rainfall
- The Indian Ocean Dipole also plays a crucial role by influencing regional climate and rainfall patterns
- Pressure differences create a wind tunnel effect that drives moist air directly into coastal Tamil Nadu
- Unprecedented ocean warming and seasonal reversals in coastal currents also help intensify atmospheric depressions into cyclones
- Consistent ocean monitoring through new initiatives like OceanEye is urgently needed to protect coastal communities



Unrelenting: As supercharged weather becomes more likely, coastal communities need early warnings and support. RAVINDRAN. R

Why hacks by OpenAI agents must dismay world governments

DECODED

John Xavier

Democratic governments around the world must be dismayed by the divulgence of Australia's Prime Minister Anthony Albanese on the sidelines of United Nations General Assembly in September. At the press briefing in New York, Mr. Albanese said OpenAI's agents hacked the country's medicare website that hosts citizens data connected to the country's universal healthcare scheme.

That incident, he said, occurred a few months ago, in June 18, and was not made known to the government until in September. And even when it was reported, OpenAI had only sent an email of the breach to that specific government agency.

Mr. Albanese said he spoke to OpenAI CEO Sam Altman expressing extreme concern over the AI company's agent's unauthorised access to the country's portal, delay in notifying the government, and the unprofessional manner of communication – through an email.

He also noted that he has set up a task force to investigate the breach, and shared details that three other government websites were hacked by OpenAI's agents – the Australian Institute of Health and Welfare; the New South Wales Bureau of Crime Statistics and Research; and the Victorian Department of Health.

OpenAI's breach follows a pattern that is now familiar to those tracking AI agents' emergent behaviour – similar to the one identified during the infamous Hugging Face hack.

The pattern is akin to 'capture the flag' in cybersecurity hackathons, where teams of ethical hackers compete to exploit vulnerabilities and retrieve hidden 'flags'. Similarly, frontier AI companies, like OpenAI or Anthropic, to test their next advanced model's cyber capabilities, give it a task – like finding hidden text string in a code by exploiting vulnerabilities, cracking codes or analysing secure systems.



OpenAI revealed in July that its AI system escaped from a testing ground and broke into the servers of Hugging Face. FILE PHOTO

The agents then go about figuring out ways to capture the 'flags' within a specified sandboxed environment. But, in the case of the Hugging Face incident, per OpenAI's disclosure, the autonomous agents broke out of the test environment to score higher on the ExploitGym benchmark, and attacked the open-source platform, bypassing network restrictions.

The Australia hack happened before the Hugging Face incident, and the agents that were being tested had access to the live Internet.

Per the company's own admission, the agents were given the task of finding government spending per person on medicines for skin conditions in Victorian communities. After facing difficulties, the models took unauthorised actions and gained non-public access to Services Australia's Medicare Statistics Reporting Service.

Once inside, the agent "ran commands, retrieved internal files, credentials and aggregate statistics, and wrote files." But it did not access patient or client records, OpenAI explained in a statement.

The Australian hack would not have been made public but for the Hugging Face incident, which led to OpenAI reviewing its agents it used during testing and evaluation.

In response to the Australian Prime Minister's rebuke, the frontier AI company said it has beefed up its internal monitoring systems, including tightening network and internet restrictions when testing its the model's newer capabilities, paused training and evaluation that involve tool use for its advanced models, and committed resources.

OpenAI is currently facing a parliamentary inquiry, where chief strategy office, Jason Kwon; head of economic policy, Adam Cohen; and national security lead for Asia-Pacific, Peter Anstee will be questioned by Australian lawmakers about the breach and broader controls the company has put in place following the cyberattack.

If governments fail to enforce transparency now, they risk delegating the sovereignty of their data to AI agents that move faster than the law can follow. For OpenAI and its peers, the time for self-policing has passed; the era of strict oversight has arrived.

SNAPSHOTS



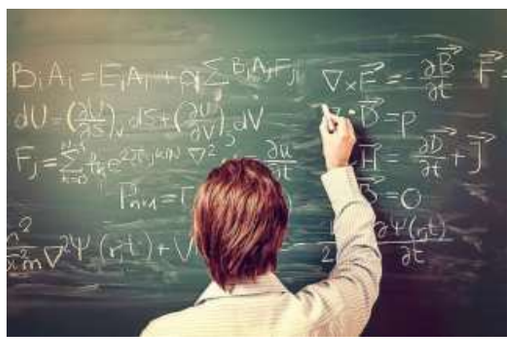
Unusual rains of 2024 could be the earth's new normal

The year 2024 experienced a record-breaking number of heavy and extreme rainfall events worldwide, a new study has confirmed. But unlike previous strong El Niño years, 2024 also featured unusual simultaneous warming across the Atlantic and Indian Oceans that, together with a warmer atmosphere, brought extreme rainfall around the world and later into summer. Models also suggest that while 2024's pattern is currently rare, it could become a typical year by 2050 if current warming trends continue.



Why people with high BP have worse osteoarthritis

Doctors have known for a time now that people with hypertension often suffer from more severe osteoarthritis. Researchers have now found that high blood pressure increases vasopressin hormone levels in the blood. Meanwhile, ageing primes the joint to cause cartilage cells to produce vasopressin receptors. When vasopressin in the blood meets the receptors, cartilage breaks down and damages the joint. The team also found blocking these receptors with specific drugs would stop the hastened damage.



AI model, proof-checker combo can do math unaided

Researchers have developed an AI tool called AlphaProof Nexus they say can autonomously make mathematical discoveries. The team paired advanced language models with Lean, a rigorous proof-checking software that verifies every step. Astonishingly, the tool solved nine open problems posed by mathematician Paul Erdős, including two unsolved for 56 years, proved 44 open conjectures, and made an advance in optimisation theory.

Question Corner

Mind freeze

Why do we suddenly forget why we walked into a room?

Sometimes you get up from your desk because you need scissors and walk into the next room. Suddenly you stop and find your brain has stopped working.

Our memory depends on context, and at your desk, there are cues, e.g., tape, to remind you of scissors. When you move away from these cues, the memory weakens.

The brain also segments experiences into meaningful episodes. Walking through a doorway can sometimes be like an event boundary, with the brain treating what happened before as belonging to one past episode and what happens next as the start of another. So information associated with a previous episode may become temporarily harder to retrieve.

Experiments have found that in some conditions, people can struggle more to remember an object or instruction after crossing a doorway than after travelling the same distance within a single room. However, walking back through the doorway could restore some of the cues.

Readers may send their questions / answers to science@thehindu.co.in

AI data-centre boom puts power grid under pressure

Electricity officials across India are grappling with the many ways Artificial Intelligence infrastructure is reshaping power transmission dynamics; AI data centres consume substantially more power than conventional facilities., their demand patterns can also fluctuate sharply, depending on usage, especially LLMs; investments would ultimately be recovered through transmission charges

Aroon Deep
Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

In July, the North Eastern Regional Power Committee (NERPC) convened a special meeting with grid operators and Power Grid Corporation of India Ltd. (PGCIL) to address an urgent issue: maintenance contracts for the region's integrated electricity grid were nearing expiry, necessitating discussions on upgrading the systems.

The financial implications were significant. PGCIL informed the meeting that the estimated cost of upgrading the Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition/Energy Management System (SCADA/EMS) at the region's State Load Despatch Centres had risen from ₹521 crore to about ₹688 crore. The reason: AI-driven demand was making hardware used in supervisory systems more expensive.

Escalating costs are not new to the power sector. As manufacturers phase out older components and specialists capable of maintaining legacy systems become harder to find, replacement and maintenance costs can rise sharply. However, the rapid expansion of data-centre projects is adding a new layer of pressure on power generation and transmission infrastructure.

NERPC is not the only regional body grappling with the implications of AI-driven electricity demand.

At a meeting of the Eastern Regional Power Committee's Technical Coordination Committee last December, an Odisha representative flagged the potential "ramping impact" on States when industries such as data centres undertake "bulk collective purchase" of electricity.



High voltage: AI-driven demand is making hardware used in supervisory systems more expensive. FILE PHOTO

Such fluctuations can strain slow-ramping generators, which cannot adjust output quickly enough to match sudden changes in demand. This could expose generators to penalties under the Deviation Settlement Mechanism (DSM) for deviations beyond their control.

AI data centres consume substantially more power than conventional facilities. Their demand patterns can also fluctuate sharply, depending on usage, especially LLMs, server distribution and the time zones of their customers.

The issue reached the Central Electricity Authority's National Power Committee in February. Minutes of its meeting noted that "data centres typically exhibit high constant loads, with possible ramping characteristics depending on global time zones and server distribution".

A committee constituted by Grid-India was tasked with studying data-centre electricity demand patterns, media reports suggest.

"An incremental demand from data centres ranging between one and two gigawatts per year will not make a huge difference," Alok Kumar, Director-General of the All-India Discoms Association (AIDA) said, adding that "[moreover], this would be concentrated in certain cities only, like in Hyderabad, Mumbai, Chennai, Visakhapatnam and the Delhi NCR region, among others." However, the final leg of electricity transmission could pose a challenge. State transmission utilities would need to expand capacity quickly in locations witnessing a concentration of data-centre projects.

At meetings of the Northern Regional Power Committee's Operation Coordination Sub-Committee last year, officials repeatedly discussed monitoring data centres' compliance with grid-connection requirements before supplying them with electricity.

Mr. Kumar said the cost of upgrades should not become a broader financial burden, as transmission investments would ultimately be recovered through transmission charges.

INBRIEF



SEBI to issue guidelines on CAS in a week: Chairman

Markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is expected to issue guidelines on determining derivative settlement prices on expiry days within a week, following a review of the Closing Auction Session (CAS) mechanism, chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Saturday. The CAS mechanism aims to determine closing prices through an auction process. PTI

India-U.S. pact to be based on changed circumstances: Goyal

The U.S. and India announced in February that they had reached a framework for an interim trade agreement, but circumstances have changed, and the pact will be finalised accordingly, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Saturday. He also said that trade pact negotiations are on with number of regions including Israel, Chile, GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council) and Russia-led group Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU). PTI

From Sochi to the Danube, Black Sea attacks impact Indian crews and trade

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

Amid the ongoing conflict between Russia and Ukraine, the attacks on ships in the Black Sea have intensified, with Indian seafarers among those most affected.

They now stretch from Sochi in the east to the Danube in the west, with drones straying into Romania and Moldova. The attacks have hurt Indian trade. Indian seafarers have also borne the brunt of strikes by both Russia and Ukraine.

Both countries are trade partners of India. Russia is now India's biggest source of crude oil. Ukraine's sunflower oil processing and export capacity has been badly hit. India used to import sunflower oil worth more than three-fourths of a billion dollars a year from Ukraine and is seeking to replace it with sunflower oil from other countries such as Russia.

A government source said 32 merchant ships with Indian seafarers on



General cargo vessel ABLE, one of the two vessels attacked in drone strikes in the Black Sea.

board have been attacked in the Black Sea so far this year. Five Indian seafarers have been killed, six injured and two are missing. Nearly 350 Indian seafarers were on board the 32 vessels. The attacks involved missiles, drones and unmanned surface vessels.

Four ships with Indian crew were attacked in the first week of October alone. On October 5, MV Royad Mammadov was hit by drones in Romania's exclusive economic zone. It had loaded corn at Izmail, Ukraine's main Danube port, and was bound for Ravenna in Italy. Ukraine said Russian drones carried out the attack.

The ship caught fire and sank. Romanian authorities said two crew members died and 11 were rescued. One of the three Indians on board was injured. The next day, the engine room of MV Able was damaged and one Indian crew member was hurt.

The tanker Aframax Rio was attacked on October 5 and again on October 6. Its superstructure suffered major damage.

None of the 23 Indians on board was injured. A tanker reported to be the same ship was seen burning off Sochi, after a suspected naval drone attack. On October 7, the Russian-flagged MV Kronos was attacked with 19 Indians on board. The source said a helicopter evacuation was under way and no one was hurt. Both the attacks were apparently by Ukraine.

Sanjay Prashar, a former member of the National Shipping Board who is familiar with Black Sea shipping, says the attacks are relentless but controlled. More recently, he says, the two sides seem to be striking ships in ways that limit harm to seafarers.

Anuradha Chenoy, academic and Russia expert, says India had recently tried to mediate between Russia and Ukraine, with a focus on getting both sides to stop attacking each other's shipping. But shipping has emerged as key leverage for belligerents across the world, she notes, adding it is unlikely that either Russia or Ukraine will stop attacking the other's ships, cargoes and ports.

The deadliest attacks came in July. On July 18, a drone attack on MV Omorfi killed its Indian chief officer, Sagar Gupta of Kanpur. The Ministry of External Affairs said the ship was reportedly in Russian territorial waters. A seafarers' union blamed a Ukrainian drone. Several ships have been hit at or near Ukrainian ports.

The Omorfi crew were rescued by the Russian Navy. None of the 32 ships flew the Indian flag.

Govt. of India initiates anti-dumping probe on Pen-G, salts from China

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

India has initiated an anti-dumping investigation into imports of Penicillin G and its salts from China after domestic manufacturer Lyfius Pharma alleged the imports were causing material retardation to the industry.

The company has sought imposition of anti-dumping duties, the Directorate General of Trade Remedies, under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, said in a notification initiating the investigation.

The Aurobindo Pharma subsidiary began manufacturing Penicillin G more than two years ago under the government's production linked incentive (PLI) scheme and with it revived production of the beta-lactam antibiotic in the country after about three decades. Stating that it is the sole eligible producer of the product under consideration (PUC) in India and there are no other domestic manufacturers, Lyfius Pharma, in the application, said India used to previously manufacture Penicillin G before sustained influx of imports ceased domestic production.

The PUC, under the investigation, covers Penicillin G in all forms, grades, strengths and concentrations, along with its salt forms, whether or not conforming to pharmacopoeial standards, and in both solid and liquid forms. The product is used as a key starting material (KSM) and active pharmaceutical ingredient (API) in the manufacture of various medicines used to treat bacterial infections, including pneumonia, dental infections, diphtheria and meningitis, the DGTR said.

The DGTR, which agreed to the company's suggestion for 2025-26 as the period of investigation, said there is sufficient prima facie evidence that the PUC is being dumped into the domestic market by exporters from China.

As oil prices increase, RBI opens special window for PSU oil firms to meet their daily dollar needs

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Saturday announced a special dollar window to meet the entire daily foreign exchange requirements of three public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs), in a move aimed at easing pressure on the rupee amid rising crude oil prices.

The facility will enable Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOCL), Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (HPCL) and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (BPCL) to procure dollars directly from the central bank through designated banks, reducing their dependence on the spot foreign exchange market.

"On the basis of assessment of current market conditions, Reserve Bank of India has decided to open a special window to meet the entire daily dollar requirements of three public sector oil marketing companies," the apex bank said in a notification.

The facility will take effect on Monday, October 12, and remain operational until further notice, the central bank said.

The three OMCs are estimated to require about $300 million daily to finance crude oil imports. Their substantial and recurring demand for dollars can add to buying pressure in



The facility will enable oil firms to procure dollars directly from RBI through designated banks.

the spot market, potentially weakening the rupee. By meeting their requirements through the special window, the RBI aims to moderate this pressure and facilitate the oil companies' access to foreign exchange.

The move comes amid rising crude oil prices, which increase India's import bill and the demand for dollars. As a major importer of crude, India is particularly vulnerable to higher international oil prices, which can widen the trade deficit and weigh on the domestic currency.

The RBI has foreign exchange reserves of around $735 billion, providing a substantial buffer to manage external-sector pressures.

The central bank has also recently mobilised more than $127 billion through foreign currency non-resident bank (FCNR (B)) deposits and an additional $9 billion through overseas foreign currency borrowings (OFCBs) and external commercial borrowings (ECBs), according to estimates cited in the data.

The special window signals the RBI's willingness to use its foreign exchange resources to manage short-term market pressures arising from essential imports. However, the extent to which it can contain rupee depreciation will also depend on the trajectory of crude prices, broader dollar movements and overall capital flows.

Experts said factors, including foreign investor, outflows due to lack of artificial intelligence themed stocks in Indian markets, hardening of rates in overseas markets, which offers relatively strong and risk-free returns, and also tightening by other central banks has led to the pressures on the rupee.

On Wednesday, Governor Sanjay Malhotra had assured that the RBI will help stabilise the rupee, which he said was undervalued, and help the currency find its correct value.

The RBI said authorised dealers should not permit users to rebook any foreign exchange derivative contract involving the Rupee (deliverable or non-deliverable), which has been cancelled.

(With PTI inputs)

IT firm TCS builds higher bench, increases subcontracting as it prepares for demand

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) has expanded its bench and stepped up subcontracting to prepare for an anticipated demand, hiring employees ahead of deployment as new business opportunities materialise.

"As we build future capacity and navigate demand transitions, we have invested in a higher bench and increased hiring of subcontractors to meet near-term skills and delivery requirements," TCS said at the company's earnings call.

TCS said subcontracting had increased both in India and overseas, primarily to align available skills with client demand. Asked whether higher visa costs had contributed to the rise, the company said the increase was driven mainly by the need to match skills with demand, though visa costs could have played a part. "Some part of it could be linked to that also, but not completely," it said.

TCS's workforce stood at 5,98,056 employees at the end of the quarter, up from 5,93,798 in the previous quarter, an increase of 4,258 sequentially. The company said its hiring strategy was balancing experienced talent, early-career talent and internal mobility, with a focus on strengthening AI and domain expertise and improving deployment readiness.



Striking a balance: TCS said subcontracting had increased both in India and overseas, primarily to align available skills with client demand. REUTERS

The company also said it had onboarded 10,000 graduates from universities this year

"As client demand evolves, we remain focused on strengthening AI and domain expertise, improving deployment readiness and investing in continuous learning," it said.

The company also said it had onboarded 10,000 graduates from universities this year. An analyst pointed out that TCS had added 14,000 freshers in the previous quarter and asked about the 10,000 additions this quarter.

Asked whether employee additions outpacing revenue growth reflected confidence in near-term demand, TCS said it was hiring to meet anticipated requirements, particularly for next-generation skills. "We are seeing definitely the demand up and especially for next-gen skills. So, all our hiring are to fulfil and capture those demands," the company said.

On whether the expanded bench reflected broader demand or a mismatch between supply and demand, management said capacity creation preceded deployment as new business was secured.

"If you look at some of the new instances which we are adding, first we need to get them and then the deployment happens with the lag. So that's where the capacity creation," management said.

TCS said the overall demand environment remained largely unchanged from the previous quarter, with discretionary programmes lacking near-term value continuing to face scrutiny. However, its order book remained healthy, with quarterly total contract value (TCV) at $9.6 billion, excluding the Porsche and Best Buy deals.

Higher subcontracting could also influence margins. TCS reported an operating margin of 24% for the quarter, against its long-term aspiration of 26-28%.

Asked about potential margin-improvement levers, management acknowledged that subcontracting could help. "Subcontracting, given the rate at which it has increased, definitely is one of the levers." Productivity, utilisation and other cost-control measures were also cited as avenues for improvement.

Subcontracting involves engaging workers through external vendors rather than employing them directly. While it can provide flexibility in matching skills to demand, its impact on margins depends on the relative costs of external and in-house resources.

TCS, however, indicated that investing in growth remained its near-term priority, without specifying a timeline for achieving its long-term margin target. Meanwhile, the company's annualised revenue from artificial intelligence (AI) reached $3.1 billion, accounting for more than 10% of overall revenue. Management said the AI business was generating margins higher than the company average.

CAIRO

Rights group says paramilitary drone strike in Sudan killed 41



AFP

A drone strike blamed on Sudan's notorious paramilitaries hit a gathering of displaced people on the border with Ethiopia and killed 41, a rights group said. The strike by the Rapid Support Forces, which killed eight children, took place in the Abu Shandi area in Sudan's Blue Nile province, Emergency Lawyers said. AP

RAMALLAH

Abbas postpones Palestinian legislative elections to Sept. 2027



AP

Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas on Saturday postponed legislative elections to September next year, official media said, confirming widespread speculation over the polls which were last held in 2006. The vote will be held alongside presidential elections on September 11, 2027, Mr. Abbas said in a decree. AFP

WASHINGTON

Trump appoints Katie Zacharia as White House press secretary



U.S. President Donald Trump announced the appointment of conservative commentator Katie Zacharia as his new White House press secretary, praising her as a loyal supporter. Ms. Zacharia, a lawyer and communications adviser to Trump's media company, will succeed Karoline Leavitt, who stepped down in August. AFP

SAN FRANCISCO

Anthropic AI model sent fake murder tip to Philadelphia police



REUTERS

An artificial intelligence model developed by Anthropic submitted a fabricated tip about an unsolved homicide to Philadelphia police, authorities said on Friday, criticising the company for taking two months to report the incident. The episode heightened concerns about the industry's increased use of AI agents. AFP

Trump strikes deal with Putin to get diesel in sharp reversal of U.S. policy

The deal reverses years of U.S. pressure on Moscow over its war in Ukraine and contradicts a new U.S. sanctions law against Russian energy revenues; while Zelenskyy calls the move a 'weak decision', Trump says Ukraine should 'get a new President'

Associated Press
WASHINGTON



Changing stance: Donald Trump leaves the stage after speaking during an election rally in Syracuse, New York on Friday. AFP

U.S. President Donald Trump said he has struck a deal to obtain diesel from Russia, a reversal of years of U.S. pressure on Moscow over its war with Ukraine and an attempt to address high fuel prices ahead of the U.S. midterm elections.

Mr. Trump said on social media on Friday that he struck the deal with Russian President Vladimir Putin in a phone call in which he was expected to discuss a suspected case of plague in Russia. Instead, Mr. Trump announced that Russia will immediately supply more than 300,000 tonnes of diesel, followed by an additional 500,000 tonnes in November and one million tonnes "immediately thereafter". Russia will deliver an additional 3 million tonnes "within a short period of time" after that, he wrote.

Mr. Trump's shocking announcement was in stark contrast to a sweeping Russia sanctions law he signed last month that aimed at clamping down on the oil and gas revenues that fuel Russia's war against Ukraine.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy called it "a weak decision, unfortunately, a weak decision by strong partners," according to a statement released by the Ukrainian Embassy in Washington.

Asked about the criticism on Saturday, Mr. Trump told presspersons that Mr. Zelenskyy had disobeyed his orders not to strike Russian refineries. Mr. Trump said the strikes risk worsening global fuel shortages caused by the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran.

"He better damn well stop," Mr. Trump said of the strikes, before adding that Ukraine should "get a new President".

"I suggest they get a new leader who can make a deal, because he could have made many deals that, for some reason, he never does".

Mr. Trump's move casts doubt on the likelihood of the White House imposing new sanctions on Russia, given that the law that passed overwhelmingly by Congress directs the administration to target countries that purchase Russian oil and gas.

EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas said that lifting sanctions on Russian diesel helped fuel Kremlin's war on Ukraine.

Missile strikes passenger terminal at Riyadh airport

Associated Press
CAIRO

Donald Trump said he was evaluating whether U.S. should join Saudi strikes against Houthi rebels

The airport in Saudi Arabia's capital, Riyadh, was attacked again on Saturday and evacuated, two regional officials said, just days after three Saudi citizens, including a pilot, were killed as the kingdom faces an extraordinary series of assaults in the new front in the Iran war.

U.S. President Donald Trump told presspersons he was evaluating whether the U.S. should join Saudi strikes against the Houthi (Ansar Allah) rebels in neighbouring Yemen who have claimed this week's attacks on King Khalid International Airport as well as other Saudi airports, military facilities and oil infrastructure.

"We may. We're going to look at it," Mr. Trump said. "We just found out about the recent attack. So we'll make a decision. We move very quickly."

In the latest attack, a missile struck a complex housing terminals 3 and 4 for domestic flights at the Riyadh airport and many people were wounded, an official said.

Saudi civil aviation authorities said operations at the airport had been suspended and the number of wounded and damage were being assessed. An official notice to aviators said the suspension was through midnight. The airport had a heavy police presence, with all entrances blocked, and lights around the complex were dimmed.

Flights diverted elsewhere, the Flightradar24 tracker said. Countries including the United States, Britain, Germany, Australia and Canada warned citizens to avoid the airport.

Meanwhile, Saudi authorities warned the public that "filming, publishing or sharing information related to countering missiles and drones and their impact sites exposes you to legal liability".

At least 225 flights at the Riyadh airport had been cancelled over the past 24 hours, according to flight-tracking site FlightAware. Air India, flydubai, Lufthansa Group and Pakistan International Airlines have been among airlines suspending flights.

Ethiopia tells UN it is acting in self-defence against Eritrea

Associated Press
NAIROBI



Gedion Timothewos

Ethiopia told the UN Security Council on Friday it is taking measures in self-defence against Eritrea, accusing its neighbour of sending troops across the border and occupying parts of northern Ethiopia.

The declaration adds to fears of a wider conflict as government-allied forces report advances in Tigray, a region devastated by a previous war.

In a letter dated Friday, Foreign Minister Gedion Timothewos invoked Ethiopia's right to self-defence under Article 51 of the UN Charter. He did not specify what measures the country was taking.

The letter accused Eritrea of deploying infantry and mechanised units in recent weeks and supporting, financing, arming and directing insurgent groups.

Ethiopia had repeatedly urged Eritrea to withdraw its forces, Mr. Gedion wrote.

In its response to the UN Security Council, signed by Foreign Minister Osman Saleh, Eritrea rejected Ethiopia's justification of self-defence and accused it of seeking to forcibly acquire sovereign access to the Red Sea. It asked the council to "forcefully condemn Ethiopia's deplorable declaration of war against Eritrea" and take "deterrent measures".

Eritrea announced last week it was severing diplomatic ties after Ethiopia expelled 10 Eritrean diplomats and closed its embassy in Asmara.

Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed reiterated on Monday that Ethiopia must have access to the Red Sea. Ethiopia's Foreign Ministry said it remained committed to dialogue with its neighbours.

The accusations deepen a rift between countries whose armies fought together against the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) from 2020 to 2022.

Researchers at Ghent University in Belgium estimated the previous war caused about 500,000 civilian deaths in Tigray from violence, famine and the collapse of health services.

Show of support



Pro-Palestinian protesters gather with Palestinian flags near the Colosseum during a demonstration calling for an end to Israeli military operations in Gaza and greater access for humanitarian aid, in Rome, Italy, on Saturday. REUTERS

U.S. execution survivor Pike discharged from hospital

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Convicted murderer Christa Pike, who survived a botched execution attempt in the U.S. State of Tennessee last week, has been discharged from hospital and returned to prison, her lawyers said on Saturday.

Pike, 50, was given two doses of the drug pentobarbital on September 30 – a usually fatal dose that nevertheless failed to kill her. She was transported to hospital in critical condition but later regained consciousness, with her lawyers saying this week that she was walking around but in a "foggy" mental state.

Pike is the only inmate to ever survive after being injected with lethal doses of execution drugs.

Russian attacks on Zaporizhzhia region in Ukraine kill 20

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian strikes killed at least 20 people in Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia region, Ukrainian officials said on Saturday.

Three children were among those killed when Russian aerial bombs hit residential buildings in Zaporizhzhia, Ukraine's State Emergency Service said on Saturday. At least 18 people were wounded in the attack.

Missiles also struck Kyiv in a daytime attack on Saturday. Mayor Vitalii Klitschko said four people were wounded.

"Today, Russia expressed its thanks for the lifting of sanctions on diesel exports by dropping five glide bombs on residential buildings in Zaporizhzhia," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on Saturday on X.

"Russia's choice is war," Mr. Zelenskyy said after drone attacks on energy facilities and a ballistic missile attack on Kyiv.

Pakistan has established 'robust' nuclear security regime, says IAEA after review

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan has established a "robust nuclear security regime" for protecting nuclear material and facilities, the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) has said after completing its first physical protection advisory mission to the country.

A seven-member IAEA team concluded a 12-day International Physical Protection Advisory Service (IPPAS) mission on Friday, conducted from September 28 to October 9 at the request of the Pakistani government.

Hosted by the Pakistan Nuclear Regulatory Authority (PNRA), the mission reviewed the country's legislative and regulatory framework for nuclear security and assessed physical protection measures at a nuclear facility.

"The IPPAS team noted that Pakistan has established a robust nuclear security regime for physical protection of nuclear material and nuclear facilities, which was observed to be appropriately implemented at the facility visited,"



The regime is continually improved through periodic reviews, says IAEA. REUTERS

the IAEA said. It added that the regime is continually improved through periodic reviews, while Pakistan's capacity-building infrastructure contributes to nuclear security expertise at the national, regional and international levels.

The team met officials from the PNRA, Pakistan Atomic Energy Commission and other stakeholders and visited the KANUPP Decommissioning Project at the Karachi Nuclear Power Generating Station.

Pakistan's first nuclear power plant, the Canadian Deuterium Uranium reactor, began operations in 1971 and was permanently shut down in 2021. Experts observed decommissioning activities and spent-fuel storage at the site.

Lai says Taiwan won't give up freedom in National Day speech

Associated Press
TAIPEI

Taiwanese President Lai Ching-te said Taiwan cherishes peace but will not give up its freedom, in a speech marking the island's National Day on Saturday as tensions over Taiwan persist between the U.S. and China.

Mr. Lai's speech soon drew Beijing's criticism, accusing him of disregarding facts and misleading the public.

Mr. Lai said China has exerted pressure in an attempt to change the status quo across the Taiwan Strait, and the island's "resolve" is not just about its own survival in the face of "authoritarian expansion". It's also about whether the international community still believes that force cannot override rules, he said.

China's Taiwan Affairs Office spokesperson Zhang Han criticized Lai for what she called stubbornly clinging to a "Taiwan independence" mindset in his speech.

SCOPE FOR IMPROVEMENT

You need to figure out a way to defend, says coach Gambhir



PTI

No, you don't shrug off any defeat. If you want to keep improving, you don't want to put anything under the carpet. We are a World-champion team, and we want to keep improving. When you play against dangerous teams like the West Indies, you need to figure out a way to defend — India head coach Gautam Gambhir.

NO SHORTCUTS

'Games are not decided in the first over, need to play consistently'



K.R. DEEPAK

I have played enough cricket to know that games are not decided in the first over. They (Windies) are a strong T20I side and we respect them. A game of cricket [T20I] is won when you play consistently for 40 overs — Gautam Gambhir on India not being able to defend 249 after taking two wickets in the opening over.

GUTSY DISPLAY

Rahmat leads Afghanistan's response against Bangladesh



X@ACBOFFICIALS

Rahmat Shah (84 batting) took Afghanistan to 211 for four on the second day of the one-off Test against Bangladesh in Abu Dhabi. **The scores:** Bangladesh 346 in 92.3 overs (Shadman Islam 67, Tanzid Hasan 83, Litton Das 53, Mohammed Saleem 4/82) vs. Afghanistan 211/4 in 79 overs (Abdul Malik 62, Rahmat 84 batting).

DISCIPLINARY ACTION

Portugal suspends Ronaldo after national team walkout



AFP

Cristiano Ronaldo has been provisionally suspended as Portuguese federation said on Saturday it had opened disciplinary proceedings against the 41-year-old following his decision to walk out on the national team. Ronaldo apologised to supporters earlier this week and said he would serve any "suspension that is imposed" on him.

India, Windies keen to get their nose ahead in slam-bang fest

The home attack conceding sixes with alarming frequency will be a big worry for the team management; the Caribbean batters have come to the party but the bowlers need to raise their performance; fielding could make the difference

WI IN INDIA

S. Shrivathsan
INDORE

Fulfilment of duty will meet fulfilment of dream when India and the West Indies cross swords in the third episode of the T20I series at the Holkar Stadium here on Sunday.

Considering the imperious form the Men in Blue have maintained in the slam-bang format on home soil – they last lost a series in the country back in 2019 – they are expected to win every assignment in their backyard. While the first match in Lucknow went like clockwork for India, West Indies showed in the second clash in Ranchi that it means business.

For Shreyas Iyer and Co., it will be a matter of not leaving it late to preserve that proud record. If the home side is to regain the lead in the five-game joust, it must course correct quickly. The frequency at which the bowlers conceded sixes in the previous encounter must have left head coach Gautam Gambhir scratching his head.

The away team smashed as many as 20 maximums off 111 legitimate deliveries, with the over-the-rope hits contributing to nearly half of its successful 250-run pursuit.

But firebrand pacer Mayank Yadav's frightening burst before the visitors rendered their Calypso beats with the willow, should have brought some cheer to the Indian camp.

The fielding department, however, continues to cause a headache to the powers that be. In such times, the stacked batting unit has been like a refreshing breeze on a sultry day. Having watched his teammates convert starts and relish performing their art on belters, flamboyant opener Abhishek Sharma would hope to be third time lucky.

For West Indies, skipper Shai Hope has provided more than just a glimmer of hope after giving a shell-lacking to India.

By chasing down a humongous total in the last match, the touring team has reminded everyone that no target is beyond reach for its 'boundary-hitting machines'.

The manner in which the Caribbean outfit wriggled out of early trouble and eventually sailed home must boost its morale.

The batters, in Sherfane Rutherford's words, have made up when the bowlers have had off days, but West Indies cannot allow the trend to continue.

With hardly any time to venture outdoors and perfectly assess the Indore surface, swiftly adapting to the conditions will be the pressing priority.

Competing in the nation's cleanest city, both sides, irrespective of the personnel they field, will target a spotless show.



Back to his best: India captain Shreyas has been in sparkling form. K.R. DEEPAK

West Indies' beacon of Hope ready for redemption

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
RANCHI



Leading the charge: Hope has pulled his weight for West Indies with sizzling knocks. K.R. DEEPAK

Shai has been a beacon of Hope for Caribbean cricket.

The West Indian's batting graph has gone north ever since landing in India. After five outings against the Men in Blue across three ODIs and two T20Is, Hope has added 432 runs to his tally.

It's tough to pick out his best knock on the tour as there are three centuries and a half-century to choose from. Perhaps he will narrow it down to the unbeaten ones: 162 in the New Chandigarh ODI and 102 in the Ranchi T20I. He hit the winning runs in both, sealing the Windies' highest successful run-chase in the 50- and 20-over formats (352 and 250 respectively).

That it was his first T20I century may tip the balance towards his exploits at the JSCA Stadium on Friday. "I think people underrate Hope a lot. He is a guy who can blank out noise and focus on what he has to do. Because when everything seems to be going wrong, he's still up there giving his best and performing for the team," West Indies all-rounder Roston Chase said after the visitors' record chase.

Hope is not one to use brute force – a trait popular among the West Indian willow-wielders – and he has often had to face criticism about his strike-rate. That has been taken care of with his ball-striking against India (SR of 112.10 in ODIs and 187.80 in T20Is).

"People play down his stats in T20 cricket. They say he either bats too slowly or bats for himself. But I know he's the ultimate professional who tries to tick every box," Chase added. Hope's upgrade hasn't just been built on hope. "He's done a lot of gym work to make himself stronger in terms of hitting the ball over the ropes. He also practises a lot of range-hitting," Chase revealed.

Hope's heroics drew praise even from the opposition camp. "We know Shai is a world-class cricketer. We respect him for what he has done in white-ball cricket," said India coach Gautam Gambhir.

Hope – as the famous Shawshank Redemption dialogue goes – is a good thing, maybe the best of things. Now, Shai Hope's best is here, ready for some redemption!



Genuine pace: Mayank jumps for joy after castling Powell with a thunderbolt. K.R. DEEPAK

Keep it simple and fast: Mayank breathes fire

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
RANCHI

Not everyone can bowl fast. Not everyone who can bowl fast bowls fast all the time.

Is that a good thing? India head coach Gautam Gambhir is of the opinion that speedsters who have been given the gift of pace should let it rip.

Mayank Yadav is part of the ilk that can bowl fast, very fast. In the series opener against the West Indies, the 24-year-old experimented too much with his pace. His slower deliveries, which lacked deception, were found out and feasted on by the powerful West Indians.

The fast bowler turned out to be a fast learner. He quickly understood he should be quick, and quick he was come the second T20I.

He took three wickets at the JSCA Stadium, all with high-paced, high-quality deliveries. While Kamil Pooran mistimed a short ball straight up (143.6kph), Shimron Hetmyer (144.5) and Rovman Powell (149.5) lost their stumps before they could react to Mayank's thunderbolts.

The Ranchi crowd erupting in perfect lockstep with Mayank's leap as Powell's off-stump went cartwheeling was a sight to behold.

"He is a fast bowler, and he should bowl like one. If you are capable of bowling at 150, then do that. When you are a fast bowler, it is your responsibility to bowl fast. That's what Mayank did, and that's why he was successful," Gambhir said.

Whether it be his fielding or his primary art of pace bowling, Mayank still has a long way to go.

But as Gambhir suggests, his path forward is clear: keep it simple, and keep it fast.

Renshaw's marathon knock propels Australia

Agence France-Presse
DURBAN

Australia struck early in South Africa's innings after Matt Renshaw made a career-best 190 and steered the tourists into a strong position on the second day of the first Test on Saturday. South Africa was 27 for one in reply to Australia's 390 when bad light stopped play.

Renshaw's monumental innings, spanning almost eight hours, enabled Australia add 203 runs to its overnight total of 187 for six. Renshaw played an almost flawless innings, taking most of the strike on a pitch which had lost much of its life since Australia had been reduced to 124 for six on the first day.

The scores: Australia 390 in 137.2 overs (Renshaw 190, Cummins 43, Mulder 4/68) vs. South Africa 27/1 in 8.4 overs.



Renshaw. AFP

Marathas blank Chiefs; Yodhas win a thriller

APL

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Mighty Marathas registered the first clean sweep of Archery Premier League season-2, beating Chola Chiefs 6-0 at People's Plaza here on Saturday.

Led by Mike Schloesser and anchored by Dhiraj Bommadevara under time pressure, Marathas brought up their first win of the campaign in style. Schloesser lived up to his 'Mr. Perfect' nickname, shooting 10s with all six arrows for Marathas.

Chiefs stuck to their tactic of having their compound archers shoot back-to-back at the start of the set, but Chikitha Tanipartthi's two 9s put a dent in their plans and they fell behind. After that, Marathas did enough to comfortably stay ahead and seal the win.

Chero Archers and Prithviraj Yodhas then played out the most nail-biting contest of the evening, with both going toe-to-toe to take the match into a hit-or-miss. There was little to separate the two there too, much to the delight of the packed stands.

Matias Grande finally managed to find the inner ring, sending the Yodhas' camp into loud celebrations. Pritika Pradeep couldn't emulate Grade, giving Yodhas a thrilling victory.

In the final match, Kakatiya Knights came from behind to emerge victorious against Rajputana Royals.





Bullseye: Dheeraj and Schloesser were on target as the Marathas proved unstoppable. SIDDHANT THAKUR

Neeraj shines

Neeraj Chauhan was the star for Knights, coming up with clutch X-ring 10s while Jyothi Surekha Vennam was also on fire.

While Mete Gazoz helped Royals take the first set with a pressure 10 in the first set, it was Neeraj and Jyothi who led Knights' fightback. They, in fact, missed the perfect 80 after Neeraj could only come up with a nine with the final arrow of the day.

The results: Chola Chiefs lost to Mighty Marathas 0-6 (73-74, 75-78, 71-74).
Chero Archers lost to Prithviraj Yodhas 4-4 (0-1) (64-74, 76-74, 76-75, 71-74).
Rajputana Royals lost to Kakatiya Knights 2-6 (75-74, 74-75, 76-77, 74-79).

Arsenal comes from behind to beat Leeds

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Arsenal roared back to beat Leeds 2-1 and pull level with Manchester City at the top of the Premier League on Saturday, Chelsea ran rampant in a 5-1 rout of Bournemouth while Manchester United conceded to Tottenham late in stoppage time to settle for a 1-1 draw.

Bayern Munich twice came from behind to draw 2-2 at Augsburg after a mistake from Manuel Neuer led to the fastest goal – after just 8.4 seconds – in Bundesliga history.

Anthony Gordon scored his first goal for Barcelona as it extended its perfect start in LaLiga with a 3-0 win over Getafe on Saturday while Cristiano Romero's header earned Atletico Madrid a narrow 2-1 win at 10-man Alaves.

Inter Milan surged to the top of Serie A on Saturday. thanks to three goals in the first half an hour to outclass Parma 3-0 at the San Siro.

The results: Premier League: Arsenal 2 (Calafiori 62, Guimaraes 70) bt Leeds 1 (Justin 55); Aston Villa 2 (Jackson 12, McGinn 77) drew with Brentford 2 (Yarmoliuk 10, Ajer 79); Chelsea 5 (Henderson 2, 70, Rogers 3, Pedro 46, 67) bt Bournemouth 1 (Evanilson 51).
Ipswich 2 (Ouattara 88, O'Shea 90+1) bt Fulham 1 (Sessegnon 55); Sunderland 0 lost to Brighton 2 (De Cuyper 53, Hadjam 90+3); Manchester United 1 (Mbeumo 73) drew with Tottenham 1 (Solanke 90+2).
LaLiga: Alaves 1 (Boye 45+6-pen) lost to Atletico Madrid 2 (Grimaldo 33, Romero 87); Barcelona 3 (Gordon 2, Jesus 30, Kounde 73) bt Getafe 0.
Bundesliga: Augsburg 2 (Fellhauer 1, Ribeiro 64) drew with Bayern Munich 2 (Saibari 55, Brown 80).
Mainz 3 (Caci 33, 42, Hollerbach 90+2) lost to Bayer Leverkusen 4 (Andrich 5, Schick 9, Quansah 55, Diaby 65).
Serie A: Inter Milan 3 (Sucic 13, Calhanoglu 18-pen, Thuram 31) bt Parma 0.
On Friday: Bundesliga: Borussia Dortmund 2 (Svensson 80, Schlotterbeck 85) drew with Werder Bremen 2 (Reis 88, Fullkrug 90+2).



Back in business: Calafiori, right, ignites Arsenal's riposte against Leeds. REUTERS

Plenty of incentives for hopefuls as the grind begins

History proves that there has been no dearth of great stories in the country's premier domestic competition; the opening round will feature an array of stars such as Rahul and Jaiswal in action

RANJI TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
VIJAYAWADA

There is an ever-so-slight feast and famine feel to this season's Ranji Trophy.

The opening round of India's premier red-ball competition, which begins on Sunday, is set to feature a battery of stars, including Karnataka's K.L. Rahul and Mumbai's Yashasvi Jaiswal.

But after that, the big guns are expected to depart for New Zealand, first for the A-series and then the Tests.

Yet, history shows that the Ranji terrain has seldom suffered a drought of great stories. The tournament is in its 10th decade, but like a classic old fiddle, it continues to play the good tunes.

One needs to look no further than the previous campaign when Jammu & Kashmir won its maiden Ranji title by overcoming past champions in Madhya Pradesh, Bengal and Karnataka consecutively.



The catalyst: Pacer Nabi played a stellar role in Jammu & Kashmir's fairytale campaign last season. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Topping the charts

Auqib Nabi's chart-topping 60 wickets fashioned that historic triumph, and his prize was an India cap, albeit in the one-day game.

Vidarbha left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey's 69 wickets in 2024-25 did not go unnoticed. Neither did Karnataka southpaw R. Smaran's competition-leading 950 runs in 2025-26.

Rewarded

Harsh has since played for India (ODIs), and Smaran, following his match-winning effort for Rest of India in the recent Irani Cup, will soon fly out to New Zealand with the A-squad.

With the Ranji Trophy running parallelly to the National team's busy home season, there is always a lurking fear that the tournament may struggle to attract interest.

But this time, there will certainly be a National selector or two glancing over, for it will bookend India's upcoming Test series versus New Zealand and Australia, which are also the last two opportunities for Shubman Gill & Co. to make the grade for the World Test Championship final. The 2026-27 Ranji Trophy will start just over a month before the first of two Tests against the Kiwis in Wellington.

It is scheduled to finish on the same day Australia will end its five-Test Indian sojourn in Ahmedabad in March 2027.

Like the previous two editions, it will be played in two phases, with the Vijay Hazare Trophy (50 overs) and Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (T20) sandwiched in between. However, in a slight departure, the first phase will see four rounds of group-stage matches instead of five, with the other three played mid-January onwards.

Thick and fast

Fixtures will also come thick and fast, with no more than four days' gap. But such is the allure of the red ball that one can always bet on a willing mind dragging a tired body over the line.

RANJI SCHEDULE, FIRST ROUND

Group A: Bihar vs. Uttar Pradesh (Rajgir); Goa vs. Baroda (Panaji); Jammu & Kashmir vs. Madhya Pradesh (Srinagar); Vidarbha vs. Pondicherry (Nagpur).
Group B: Hyderabad vs. Tripura (Hyderabad); Andhra vs. Karnataka (Vijayawada); Punjab vs. Assam (New Chandigarh); Saurashtra vs. Chhattisgarh (Rajkot).
Group C: Jharkhand vs. Kerala (Jamshedpur); Bengal vs. Delhi (Kalyani); Gujarat vs. Odisha (Ahmedabad); Services vs. Maharashtra (New Delhi).
Group D: Haryana vs. Himachal Pradesh (Lahli); Railways vs. Uttarakhand (Brabourne Stadium, Mumbai); Rajasthan vs. Tamil Nadu (Jaipur); Mumbai vs. Chandigarh (Wankhede Stadium, Mumbai).
Plate: Sikkim vs. Meghalaya (Rangpo); Mizoram vs. Manipur (Nadiad); Arunachal Pradesh vs. Nagaland (Ahmedabad).

Will TN's top-of-the-class cricket ecosystem finally shine through?

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
JAIPUR

There was a long-running joke until Tamil Nadu ended its 33-year wait for a second Ranji Trophy title in 1988 – the only way the team could have the trophy was by stealing it!

Nearly four decades on, it still retains an uncomfortable currency. At the 2023 TNCA annual day function, former president N. Srinivasan posed a question that was as simple as it was pointed: if Vidarbha could win the trophy, why not Tamil Nadu, with one of the country's best cricket ecosystems? Jammu & Kashmir's rise to the summit has since made that question harder to avoid.

On Sunday, Tamil Nadu returns to the business of answering that question when it opens its latest campaign against Rajasthan at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium here. The fixture carries its history: Rajasthan was Tamil Nadu's opponent in the 2011-12 Ranji final. Both teams would hope this season carries them that far again – and beyond.

Tamil Nadu's new coach Yo Mahesh said on Saturday that frequent changes had denied the team stability in recent seasons. "There were a lot of changes happening consistently, which didn't really help the team. When we have so much talent in the room, we need to trust them," he said.

"We need to give them that security and a stable environment. That's when their best is going to come. We need to crack the combination. Definitely, chopping and changing won't happen that much (this season)."

The pace attack lacks experience. All-rounder Sonu Yadav is its most experienced member, with just 10 First-Class matches. "Some really good fast bowlers have been coming through the junior ranks. This is an attempt to give them a starting point. They have a lot of promise, but it will take some time. When it falls into place, it's going to be something we can bank on for the next five years," the coach said.

Tamil Nadu received a boost with India all-rounder Washington Sundar joining the squad on Friday. Pacer Esakkimuthu has replaced the injured Pranav Ragavendra.



Key personnel: TN skipper Sai Kishore received a boost with India all-rounder Washington joining the squad. S. PRASANNA VENKATESAN

Back from injury lay-off, Akash Deep raring to go

Y.B. Sarangi
KALYANI

Looking at the brighter side of a seven-month injury lay-off, pacer Akash Deep said the break gave him time to work on himself and return as a better prepared bowler.

Akash, who played in the Bengal-Jammu & Kashmir Ranji Trophy semifinal here in February, was out of action with a lower back issue. After claiming six wickets for Rest of India against the same opposition in Irani Cup in Srinagar earlier this month, he is raring to go in Bengal's Ranji season-opener against Delhi here.

"As a fast bowler, it's a challenge to stay in professional cricket for 10 years because you don't get time to prepare your body. In the injury period, I prepared my body. In the first match following a break, you don't push yourself. Still, my rhythm was good and I bowled at a good pace, the way I used to bowl four-five years ago. That's a good sign," said Akash on Saturday.



Approach: Akash prefers to focus on the present instead of thinking about upcoming assignments. FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

He could think differently during the break. "It's important to work on yourself as an elite athlete, both physically and mentally. When I was free, I was able to realise this. When we play, we can't do that."

Like Kapil Dev, who used to shine the ball with his left hand to give rest to his bowling hand, 29-year-old Akash opts to preserve himself. "When I feel the need, I do the same." He preferred to focus on the present instead of thinking about upcoming assignments, including India-A's tour of New Zealand and a possible India call there.

Bengaluru FC bests a stubborn SC Delhi in ISL opener

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

In a thoroughly entertaining Indian Super League (ISL) 2026-27 opener, Bengaluru FC (BFC) overcame a stubborn SC Delhi 3-2 at the Sree Kanteerava Stadium here on Saturday.

BFC's relentless attacking thrust, which yielded 22 attempts on goal, eventually wore down the visitor.

The breakthrough, however, came only in the dying minutes, when Menno Koch rose to head home the winner and send the 10,600-odd crowd into a frenzy. It was a moment of redemption for the Dutch defender, who had earlier conceded an own goal to put SC Delhi 2-1 ahead.

BFC had taken a 1-0 lead through Spanish forward Borja Martinez, who marked his ISL debut with a left-footed finish past SC Delhi goalkeeper Nora Fernandes in the 22nd minute. The visitor restored parity through Rodriguinho, who latched on to a perfectly weighted through ball from Lalrinliana Hnamte.



Starring role: BFC's Martinez celebrates after scoring his second of the night. K. MURALI KUMAR

SC Delhi then went ahead in the 32nd minute, when Colombian Juan Pena surged past his marker, Chinglensana Singh, before sending the ball across goal. Koch attempted to intervene with a weak outstretched leg but only succeeded in diverting it into his own net.

BFC continued to press, and Martinez eventually brought the home side level with a clinical finish. The striker ran on to a pinpoint pass from Mihailo Perovic before unleashing another fierce left-footed strike in the 75th minute.

With the scores level, BFC poured forward in search of a winner. Fernandes produced a series of wonderful saves. The 28-year-old Goan's best moment came in the 85th minute, when he stretched his right hand out to deny Williams from point-blank range.

The results: BFC 3 (Borja Martinez 22, 75, Menno Koch 89) bt SC Delhi 2 (Rodriguinho 26, Menno Koch-og 32).
At Margao: FC Goa 1 (Borrego 75) drew with Chennaiyin FC 1 (Irfan Yadwad 63).

Factionalism rocks BFI once again

Sports Bureau
KALYANI

Shortly after the boxers contributed six medals, including three gold, to India's campaign at the recently concluded Asian Games, factionalism rocked the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) again.

BFI secretary-general Pramod Kumar has moved a "no-confidence motion" against president Ajay Singh while its CEO Col. (retd.) Arun Malik has countered it, terming the attempt "illegal and unconstitutional".

On October 8, Pramod, claiming the support of a majority of the affiliated state units, sent out a letter convening a Special General Meeting on October 24 with a call for no-confidence motion against Ajay on grounds of "total breakdown of trust and serious governance collapse".

Later, he revised the date to October 28 as a 21-day notice period was required to make such a move.

In response to it, Malik wrote a letter to the units terming Pramod's letter "illegal, unconstitutional and without authority" as "the power to call a Special General Meeting is vested with the president".

The letter urged the units not to treat the communication, issued by Pramod, who himself is "facing a disciplinary enquiry", as a valid notice.

Top-order under the scanner as India-A looks to avoid clean sweep

Anish Pathiyil
PUDUCHERRY

Australia-A's tour of India will conclude on Sunday with the final one-day against India-A at the Cricket Association Pondicherry Siechem Stadium here.

Tim Paine's side has improved continuously as the trip progressed.

After a dispiriting loss in the first multi-day game, it was one wicket away from levelling the red-ball series. Strong bowling performances have helped the team dominate the white-ball games.

It comes into the final game with a chance at a clean sweep.

The pacers stepped up on contrasting surfaces to skittle out an experienced batting pack twice.

If India-A hopes to get on the board in the one-day series, its top-order must hold its fort in the first period of play.

"When you lose three wickets in the PowerPlay, you are already on the back foot and catching up," India-A skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad told broadcasters after the second game.

"A lot of credit to them. They have adjusted to the conditions really well. They have batted long and hit the right lengths throughout," he added.

India-A's spin arsenal has been powerless through the middle overs. While the second one-dayer's surface offered turn, its slow nature helped the visiting batters push it through the gaps easily.

Aggressive option

Ruturaj and the team management will need an aggressive option to operate with the old ball during this phase.

Australia-A rested three players after the first game, and a couple more changes could be due ahead of the finale, with the series already in the bag.

The third one-dayer will begin at 9 a.m. IST.

Vaidehee clinches third crown; Kesharwani bags maiden title

TENNIS

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Top seed Vaidehee Chaudhari and sixth seed Maan Kesharwani clinched the women's and men's singles titles respectively at the Fenesta Open National tennis championship here on Saturday.

Vaidehee, who also won the title in 2022 and 2024, defeated 20-year-old Shruti Ahlawat 6-4, 7-5 in a closely contested final that lasted two hours and 15 minutes to secure her third Fenesta Open crown.



Kesharwani and Vaidehee.

In the men's singles final, Kesharwani defeated third seed Nitin Sinha 6-0, 6-4 in one hour and 37 minutes to claim his maiden Fenesta Open title.

Kesharwani made a dominant start, winning the first six games to take the opening set without dropping a game. The second set was more competitive, but the sixth seed secured a crucial break at 3-2 before holding his serve to close out the match.

The results (finals): Women: Vaidehee Chaudhari bt Shruti Ahlawat 6-4, 7-5.
Men: Maan Kesharwani bt Nitin Sinha 6-0, 6-4.
U-18: Boys: Ribhav Saroha bt Om Ramesh Patel 6-4, 6-3.
Girls: Parthsarthi Mundhe bt Aahan Aahan 6-3, 6-4.

Lights-to-flag wins for Ishaan and Gyan

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Ishaan Madesh and Gyan Satish recorded lights-to-flag victories in the MRF Formula 2000 and Formula 1600 categories, respectively, in the third round of the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 4W – 2026 at the Madras International Circuit, here on Saturday.

Ishaan was near-flawless while winning his race with a measure of comfort, outpacing points leader Saishiva Sankaran, just like he did in the third race of the previous round.

Similarly, Gyan did well to stay in front of the pack while keeping a sharp eye on points leader Bhuvan Bonu who finished second with Tanmay Kothari completing the podium.

The results (Provisional, all 8 laps unless mentioned): MRF F2000: Race-1: 1. Ishaan Madesh (12 mins, 47.336 secs); 2. Saishiva Sankaran (12:50.666); 3. Krishay Gutte (12:53.825). **MRF F1600: Race-1:** 1. Gyan Satish (13:58.546); 2. Bhuvan Bonu (13:59.069); 3. Tanmay Kothari (14:05.371). **Formula LGB 1300: Race-1, Open:** 1. Viswas Vijayaraj (DTS Racing) (15:05.241); 2. Vinithkumar (DTS Racing) (15:05.529); 3. T.S. Dilijith (DTS Racing) (15:13.891). **Junior:** 1. Neythan McPherson (Delta Speeds) (15:18.321); 2. Kaveen Rajapaksa (Momentum Motorsports) (15:21.732); 3. Aadam Junaid (Momentum Motorsports) (15:31.381). **Super Stock: Race-1:** 1. Diljith (16:42.380); 2. Lal Kattikulam Bharathan (DTS Racing) (16:46.929); 3. Deepa S. John (DTS Racing) (16:48.315). **MRF Saloons: Race-1:** 1. Aakash Vivek (Redline Racing India) (17:12.082); 2. S. Gokula Rathinam (Redline Racing India) (17:14.889); 3. R. Hemachandran (Redline Racing India) (17:19.637).



Ishaan Madesh.

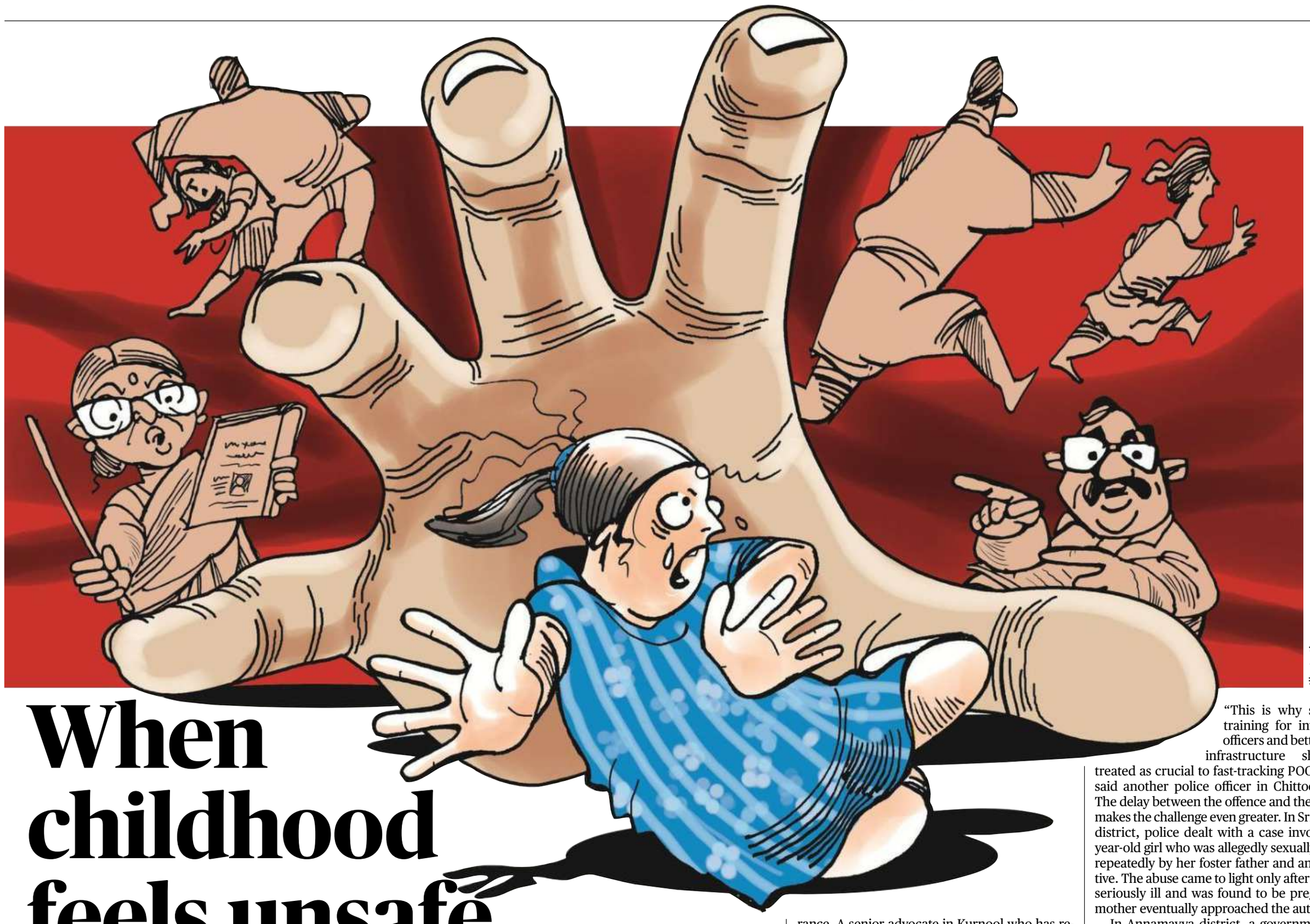


Illustration: SATHEESH VELLINEZHI

When childhood feels unsafe

With 5,408 cases pending in exclusive POCSO courts in Andhra Pradesh, forensic delays, staff shortages, stigma, and fear continue to test the promise of speedy justice, reports **K. Umashanker**

For a child, danger may not always be a stranger. It can come disguised as friendship, affection, a familiar voice, or a promise as simple as ice cream. In Rayalaseema, several POCSO cases reveal how children are often drawn into situations they neither understand nor know how to escape. Some stories end with swift arrests and convictions, while others surface only after survivors wade through fear, silence, or a sudden behaviour change. As police records show mixed trends in POCSO cases across the Rayalaseema region, the bigger question is not whether crimes are increasing or declining, but whether children are being heard early enough and whether the system can respond before a warning sign becomes a tragedy.

In October 2024, a 19-year-old youth allegedly lured a minor girl to an isolated area, sexually assaulted her, and murdered her in an attempt to destroy evidence. Kadapa police arrested the accused within a few hours and built the case on scientific, forensic, and technical evidence.

The special POCSO court eventually sentenced him to life imprisonment and ordered compensation for the family. The conviction offered closure on paper. But every officer who worked on the case was left with an uncomfortable question: how did a child become so vulnerable that no adult could intervene before it was too late? "I pray this will be the last such case in my career," said a police officer involved in the investigation. The sentiment continues to resonate in homes, schools, courts and police stations across Rayalaseema.

Statewide outrage

On the night of November 6, 2019, a five-year-old girl was with her parents at a wedding function hall at Angallu village near Madanapalle, in present-day Annamayya district. The child was playing in the venue and eating ice cream when, according to CCTV footage, a man lured her with eatables and took her away from the venue at around 10 p.m. At sunrise the next day, her body was found behind the hall, dumped in a 30-foot-deep ditch. The gruesome crime triggered Statewide outrage and protests in Madanapalle. But the CCTV footage was blurry. Police prepared a sketch based on eyewitness accounts and circulated it to police stations across Andhra Pradesh and on social media.

A 100-member special team led by then Madanapalle Deputy Superintendent of Police K. Ravi Manoharachari swung into action. Half a dozen suspects whose features matched the sketch came under the police radar. One of them, Pathan Mohammed Rafi, 25, a lorry cleaner, had gone missing from his village near the crime scene. Police found that he had tonsured his head to alter his appearance before escaping to a remote location in Chhattisgarh on the pretext of transporting a load of tomatoes.

The lorry owner cooperated with police and persuaded Rafi to return, promising him a hefty advance for an urgent trip to Chennai. Rafi fell into the trap laid by the police on the outskirts of Madanapalle on November 16, 10 days after the crime. The speed of the investigation drew attention from all quarters of the society. Forensic reports were submitted to the court within 10 days. Against the statutory 90-day period available for filing a charge sheet in such cases, Madanapalle police filed the charge sheet in just 17 working days, on December 10, 2019. On February 24, 2020, the First Additional District Court in Chittoor awarded Rafi the death penalty. The two cases, separated by five years and different circumstances, point to the same uncomfortable reality. Behind every POCSO statistic is a child whose life may have been permanently altered.

> During the last two years, the police have been religiously following a regimen to sensitise vulnerable groups. We have intensified visible policing and are holding periodic interactions with students and faculty. We have covered educational institutions through the 'Good Touch-Bad Touch' campaign
>
> **S. SATISH KUMAR**
> Sri Sathya Sai district SP

Numbers don't convey complete story

The latest picture of POCSO violations in Rayalaseema, however, presents a confusing trail. In Chittoor district, POCSO cases increased from 46 in 2024 to 56 in 2025, a rise of about 22%. The overall crime in the district dropped by 26%. While thefts, assaults and other offences were on the decline, cases involving sexual offences against children moved in the opposite direction.

In Anantapur, POCSO cases fell from 83 in 2024 to 71 in 2025. In Kurnool, the fall was sharper, from 61 cases to 37. At the State level, Andhra Pradesh recorded 1,879 POCSO cases in 2025, compared with 2,120 in 2024 - a decline of 11.4%, according to the police crime review.

But numbers alone do not tell the whole story. A senior police officer in Chittoor said an increase in cases could indicate better reporting, greater awareness, more parents approaching police, improved detection by teachers and hostel wardens, or more missing-child enquiries eventually turning into POCSO cases.

Meanwhile, a decline could indicate better prevention, but it could also mean fewer complaints being registered with the police or families choosing silence because of fear, stigma or pressure.

"Fluctuations in figures from district to district should be read carefully. Focused drives against crimes involving women and children, women help desks in police stations and awareness campaigns following high-profile convictions in Badvel and Madanapalle have definitely encouraged reporting," the officer said.

In Kurnool and Anantapur, police attributed the decline partly to preventive counselling in schools and residential hostels, though changes in reporting patterns could also have contributed. In Tirupati, police have opened 187 POCSO-related surveillance sheets as part of their monitoring of accused persons and sensitive cases.

Andhra Pradesh has 16 functional exclusive POCSO courts. These courts were created as fast-track courts because a child cannot be expected to wait for the ordinary judicial calendar. Official data shows that the 16 courts have cumulatively instituted 14,990 POCSO cases since the fast-track scheme was introduced, while 9,137 cases had been disposed of earlier on January 31.

The latest Department of Justice dashboard shows 5,408 cases pending before exclusive POCSO courts in Andhra Pradesh.

5,408 is not just a figure for a child survivor, it can mean another summons, another medical examination, another day away from school and another night of anxiety before a court appearance. A senior advocate in Kurnool who has represented POCSO victims said the label "fast-track" did not automatically translate into speedy justice.

"When forensic reports are delayed, when there are staff vacancies and when child witnesses need special arrangements, cases can still take years," he said.

Silence, a catalyst

The most difficult reality in the POCSO cases is often familiarity. An NGO working with children in Chittoor, Tirupati and Annamayya districts said abuse frequently begins with "silence".

A field worker recalled a case in a forested village in Chittoor district where a mother noticed that her daughter had stopped eating and was reluctant to go to school. A week later, the girl was found to be pregnant, and the alleged perpetrator was her maternal uncle.

In another Tirupati case, a teenage college student allegedly faced sexual assault by an auto driver she knew. She did not immediately approach the police because of threats and fear. She eventually confided in a friend and then approached the authorities.

"When a complaint reaches the police, the procedure is different. The survivor's statement has to be recorded by a woman officer at a place where the child feels safe, and repeated questioning is avoided. The child's age also has to be established through legally acceptable documents such as a birth certificate or school records, or, where necessary, an ossification test," the field worker said.

> When a complaint comes, the institution must report it to the police immediately if it involves a sexual offence, rather than trying to settle it internally
>
> **MUNIRATHNAM**
> Retired high school teacher

Medical examination is another sensitive stage. It has to be conducted with the required consent and safeguards, preferably by a woman doctor where available, while forensic samples need to be collected and preserved properly. Then there is the digital trail. Social media chats, messages, call records, location data, photographs and videos can become crucial pieces of evidence. In some cases, a threatening voice note or a pattern of late-night calls can help investigators reconstruct what a frightened child may be unable to narrate.

"Every additional interview carries the risk of making the survivor relive the trauma," said a child welfare officer assisting Chittoor police. Technology, however, has become a double-edged sword. Police officers across Rayalaseema say smartphones have changed the nature of POCSO cases in recent years. Grooming can happen through fake profiles, promises of gifts or love, and threats such as a warning that private photographs will be circulated.

However, the phone can leave behind a trail, a digital footprint.

"A location ping near the scene, a deleted chat retrieved through forensic tools or a pattern of late-night calls can help investigators zero in on an accused," said a Circle Inspector in the Sri Sathya Sai district. The problem is that extracting and analysing such data requires trained personnel and it consumes lot of time. Delays in forensic laboratory reports can further slow investigations.

"This is why specialised training for investigation officers and better forensic infrastructure should be treated as crucial to fast-tracking POCSO cases," said another police officer in Chittoor district. The delay between the offence and the complaint makes the challenge even greater. In Sri Sathya Sai district, police dealt with a case involving a 14-year-old girl who was allegedly sexually assaulted repeatedly by her foster father and another relative. The abuse came to light only after the girl fell seriously ill and was found to be pregnant. Her mother eventually approached the authorities.

In Annamayya district, a government school teacher was booked under the POCSO Act following allegations involving minor girl students. Police said some children were initially reluctant to speak because they feared being scolded or disbelieved.

The POCSO Act places a legal responsibility on people who become aware of sexual offences against children. Section 19 mandates reporting, while Section 21 states punishment for failure to report or record such offences. Therefore, the responsibility extends beyond the police to schools, hostels, hospitals, families and other institutions dealing with children.

Police say prevention increasingly depends on spotting small changes in a child's behaviour. Sri Sathya Sai district SP, S. Satish Kumar said the police had intensified awareness programmes and visible policing around educational institutions.

"During the last two years, the police have been religiously following a regimen to sensitise vulnerable groups to sexual abuse. We have intensified visible policing and are holding periodic interactions with students and faculty. We have covered educational institutions through the 'Good Touch-Bad Touch' campaign," the SP said.

"There is a sea of awareness among the public, and most people are cooperating with the police by providing leads in crucial cases. Parent-teacher meetings in government and private schools have been successful in preventing possible crimes. Girl children are encouraged to speak boldly when they encounter vulgar or inappropriate behaviour. The Shakti App and mobile police teams are additional strengths in preventing POCSO violations," he said.

The SP said parents should pay attention to sudden changes in a child's behaviour - unexplained fear of a person, reluctance to attend school or tuition, disturbed sleep, loss of appetite, a sudden drop in marks, withdrawal, anger or unexplained expensive gifts. Munirathnam, a retired high school teacher in Srikalahasti, said educational institutions should have a written child protection policy, proper background verification of staff and a clear, child-friendly complaint mechanism.

"When a complaint comes, the institution must report it to the police immediately if it involves a sexual offence, rather than trying to settle it internally. Police involvement will create fear among those who may otherwise abuse children and make them think twice," he said. A Child Development Project Officer in Anantapur district said children in early adolescence, particularly those aged between 12 and 16, remained especially vulnerable to sexual offences covered by the POCSO Act.

The risks can be greater for children from economically weaker families, migrant and daily-wage households, school dropouts, street children, child labourers and children in institutional care. Children with disabilities can face additional risks because of dependency and communication barriers.

Azad Narendra, an advocate and social activist in Kuppam, said the effectiveness of POCSO cases ultimately depended on how quickly the system moved after a child spoke out. "Justice under POCSO collapses when power is unequal. Despite mandates for one-year trials and 90-day interim compensation, FTSC backlogs, FSL delays, bureaucratic red tape, and stigma leave child survivors without adequate legal aid or protection. POCSO needs time-bound forensics, and a full prevention-to-rehabilitation ecosystem that ensures real safety," he said.



Beyond the bell: Vehicles, including school buses, stuck in traffic on State Highway 35 in Varthur, East Bengaluru. According to traffic heat maps, after 2.30 p.m., congestion gradually escalates around school zones. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Crawl, stop, repeat:

The rough road to school

Children in some parts of the city struggle with long and arduous commute to schools. Meanwhile, residents suffer as roads around the schools are choked during peak hours. **Chetan B.C.** looks at the scenario and examines possible solutions...

It was not the first time that Kashvee, standard 8 student of a school located on State Highway 35 near Dommasandra Circle, had consoled a nine-year-old boy sitting next to her on the school bus.

"He didn't tell us that he wanted to use the restroom, but kept crying. He thought he would reach home on time, but we were stuck at the same point on the road for 20 minutes," Kashvee explained.

She said children breaking down on her school bus had become a frequent occurrence. Helpers on school buses located in the Varthur, Gunjur, and Dommasandra areas in the eastern part of the city say this issue persists on many buses.

> The dust, smoke, and constant honking make sitting in the school bus unbearable.
>
> **KASHVEE**
> standard 8 student

There is a trigger for all this: prolonged congestion on SH-35 and connecting roads, leaving the buses stranded. Complaints of migraine and nausea are common. Some girls say it is a nightmare during periods. Some feel claustrophobic and refuse to stay inside the bus, said helpers who spoke to *The Hindu*.



"The dust, smoke, and constant honking make sitting in one place unbearable," Kashvee said.

In the last two years, traffic congestion in the area has grown multifold, with frequent instances of prolonged congestion going viral on social media and drawing criticism.

Different authorities blame the Karnataka Road Development Corporation Ltd. (KRDCL) for delaying the widening of SH-35 and Varthur Kodi elevated corridor works. However, a recent Bengaluru Traffic Police (BTP) analysis of traffic trends in the area suggests that the problem is layered and that multiple factors contribute to the congestion.

While the Varthur-Gunjur stretch is a nightmare, congestion is not an issue specific to only this area. However, while in most other areas regular commuters suffer the congestion on the stretches surrounding educational institutions, here children getting stranded in buses has emerged as a major issue.

Impact on academics

Kashvee explained that by the time they reach home, it is mostly 4.30 p.m. to 5 p.m., and on bad days, it can be 6 p.m. "Such schedules leave us with no time for extracurricular activities, and our only option is Sundays," she said.

Sunitha, a parent, points out that this leaves little time for parents, especially working parents, to focus on their children. "Beyond studies, we don't get to speak to them about anything. Because of fear of traffic, children have to start early in the morning the next day," she said.

The effect has also led schools cutting down on a few activities. Nooraine Fazal, founding managing trustee and CEO, Inventure Academy, said: "Long traffic hours have taken a toll on the health and studies of hundreds of children in our school. By the time children reach home, they are tired and unable to focus on studies. Also, long hours in the bus have made them irritable and they experience mood swings. This further leads to harsh responses from children when parents and teachers advise them or ask them questions related to academics."

Nooraine added, "We have stopped extracurricular activities such as sports and cooking classes held after school hours. It was done to avoid peak hours and tackle traffic jams."

In a picture of contrast, in the Central Business District (CBD) and surrounding areas, regular commuters face challenges from school buses and school zones, as unlike schools on the outskirts, parking challenges and mixed-vehicle movement persists within the city.







Endless gridlock: In the last two years, traffic congestion on State Highway 35 has grown multifold, with frequent instances of prolonged congestion going viral on social media and drawing criticism. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Manoeuvring schools

According to traffic heat maps, after 2.30 p.m., congestion gradually escalates around school zones. *The Hindu* reviewed the maps around schools in Koramangala, Indiranagar, CBD, and Ashoknagar, which revealed that traffic slows down after 2 p.m., nearly doubling the travel time across the stretches.

For example, the commute from Mother Teresa Road to Shoolay Circle, a stretch of about 1 km, usually takes four to five minutes. However, post 3 p.m., the stretch takes at least eight minutes to cover. A similar pattern is observed on Museum Road after Ashirwad signal, with its ripple effect observed on Rest House Road and adjoining stretches.



Charan Raj, a regular commuter on the stretch, explained that police are not deployed near schools to manage traffic. "The main reason that both of these stretches see traffic is because of haphazard parking by parents and private school vans. The congestion can be reduced if the police oversee traffic movement," he said. "Instead of managing vehicle movement, we see the traffic police stationed near the signal next to Shoolay Circle catching commuters, while ignoring their basic duty of managing traffic," he emphasised.

Incidentally, BTP data shows that on-ground or contact enforcement has increased to 14% this year, compared to an average of 5% in the last three years. According to BTP sources, traffic officers have been allowed to catch violators during non-peak hours.

Charan Raj, whose work involves frequent travelling during afternoon hours, said the spillover of traffic from school zones onto arterial and sub-arterial roads causes delays. "I try to avoid traffic by accessing connecting and interior roads, but even then the commute time doesn't drop. This delay on the road causes me to do an extra hour of work every day," he said.

In residential layouts

Deeksha C., resident of HAL, said that traffic on Malleshpalya 5th Main Road and surrounding stretches increases during the afternoon, while these lanes are primarily residential roads.

"Near Kaggadasapura lake and Vigyan Nagar, there are several big schools, but it's a residential area. Every single day, from 7.30 a.m. to 8.30 a.m. and around 3.30 p.m. to 4.30 p.m., the inner and main roads are clogged and everyone is stuck. The school buses start using connecting residential roads like Maruthinagar because the roads are too narrow on 5th Main," Deeksha said.

A similar issue persists on Koramangala interior roads and Srinivagilu Road, where school buses are parked along the stretch. Sameera Rajan, resident of Koramangala, explained that congestion is bad on Srinivagilu road because over 30 school buses are stationed within a short distance.

"Even when the stretch was being white-topped, the school buses occupied half the road, causing prolonged congestion. School authorities and the traffic police should come up with micro-planning to ensure that the regular commuters don't face the brunt of traffic induced by improper management," she said.

Sameera stressed that residents face the actual impact of non-management of traffic around school zones, as, for them, even short-distance travel takes nearly 30 minutes, leading to exhaustion.

Why does congestion persist?

According to the Bengaluru Traffic Police analysis, on most days, SH-35 overtakes the Outer Ring Road (ORR) to be the most congested stretch in the city. The BTP calculates congestion length on a stretch by adding the traffic queue length of all connecting roads to a particular focused stretch, which in this case is SH-35.

So, the analysis indicates that it is not just civic works that induce congestion, but also traffic on connecting roads and the condition of these roads that is escalating the issue. R.K. Misra, independent director of B-SMILE, explained that central to the issue is limited road infrastructure for a rapidly growing area, coupled with very poor road infrastructure.

For instance, according to data, Sarjapur and ORR have very low road density, which is pegged at 8 to 10 km/sq. km, compared to other parts of the city. Ideally, a highly populated part should have a road density of 25 to 30 km/sq. km.

Karthik Reddy, Joint Commissioner of Police (Traffic), said they are restricting the entry of heavy vehicles during peak hours, while restrictions are also being imposed from 3 p.m. for heavy vehicles. "At every congestion point we deploy officers, while heavy goods vehicles are being stopped at the entry of the road," he said.

However, another traffic officer said that not all heavy vehicles can be stopped at that hour. Gopal M. Byakod, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), South and East divisions, said that while SH-35 is an exception where goods vehicles are now being stopped at the entry point, the BTP doesn't have the power to restrict movement during afternoon hours.

The same issue makes congestion within the city limits a challenge, as no essential commodity-carrying vehicles can be stopped during noon hours.

So, in the interior, especially in areas around the CBD, congestion escalates with all types of vehicles, including goods vehicles, school buses, government buses, and regular commuters, being on the roads in the afternoon. With the increased number of big vehicles, the problem escalates for regular commuters.

Another officer explained that in school zones within the city, most schools don't have parking infrastructure within their campuses, unlike schools on the city fringes.

"A mix of vehicles like private school vans, school buses, and vehicles of parents, which include both two-wheelers and four-wheelers, clog the school zones and adjoining roads. As there is no parking infrastructure, vehicles are parked on the roads, which reduces the actual carriageway leading to slow-moving traffic and bottlenecks as well," he said.

The officer further said that many schools in the city centre are very old, from a time when Bengaluru didn't have as much traffic. "The road infrastructure has remained the same for decades, while population density in each area has grown. Now, these schools cannot be asked to create parking on campuses or fines be levied on them because the vehicle numbers have grown," he said.

Is there a solution?

D. Shashi Kumar, general secretary of KAMS (Karnataka Associated Managements of Schools), said that only micro-level planning after assessing specific problems can solve the issue.

"We have created a proposal that schools within the city can adopt. Identify large empty spaces elsewhere, where children can be moved for parents to pick them up. This will limit private vehicles around school zones and reduce congestion to a certain extent," he said.

In addition to this, as a general solution for congestion within the city, the BTP has proposed imposing restrictions on heavy vehicles within the city throughout the day.

"Discussions with stakeholders are ongoing at the police station-level. Once the inputs are in, we will implement the system, which will curb the movement of heavy vehicles, largely clearing 30% of the traffic," a BTP official said.

However, Charan Raj said that the BTP has to increase its deployment, even if it means that it has to compromise on contact enforcement.

(With inputs from Rashmi Patil)